

Justice Shah nail **Page 1** grievances at SC door

By Nasir Iqbal

ISLAMABAD: Ahead of a full court meeting that is supposed to give a final nod to the Supreme Court Rules 2025, senior puisne judge Justice Syed Mansoor Ali Shah on Friday questioned why this historic revision of the rules made in 1980 was ‘approved by circulation’, rather than after discussion in the full court.

In a strongly-worded seven-page letter to Chief Justice of Pakistan (CJP) Yahya Afridi, Justice Shah wondered whether he was “nurturing independence among judges or enforcing compliance to turn this court into a regimented force”.

As the senior-most judge of the top court, Justice Shah said, he was writing with reluctance, but in discharge of an unavoidable institutional duty.

“What compels me to write is your persistent and complete indifference,” Justice Shah regretted, adding that his repeated letters and written communications to the CJP on several issues had gone unanswered and

Continued on Page 3

Announcement

Page 1
THE OFFICE of *Dawn*
will remain closed on Sept
6 on account of Eid
Miladun Nabi (PBUH).
There will be no newspa-
per on Sunday.

Balochistan takes priority over flood discussion in NA

Page 1

Lawmakers slam govt's handling of situation in the province; cite ongoing 'military ops', failure to address missing persons' issue

By Amir Wasim

ISLAMABAD: The 'worsening' law and order situation in Balochistan overshadowed the ongoing debate on the flood situation in the National Assembly on Friday as the lawmakers belonging to the province protested over the alleged government's failure to protect life and property of the citizens in the wake of recent spike in terrorism incidents.

The house also passed a resolution "condemning in the strongest words" the recent suicide bombing at the public meeting of the BNP-Mengal in Quetta and "demanding of the provincial government to bring the perpetrators to justice."

The resolution, read out by Pullain Baloch of the National Party (NP), said that 15 people died and more than 75 people were injured in the incident.

The blast took place near Shahwani Stadium in Quetta's Sariab area on Tuesday night, shortly after the conclusion of the public meeting of the

BNP-M held to mark the death anniversary of late Sardar Attaullah Mengal.

BNP President and MNA Akhtar Mengal, who presided over the gathering, remained unhurt as the blast occurred when he was leaving for home. PkMAP chief Mehmood Khan Achakzai, Asghar Khan Achakzai of the ANP, and former senator Mir Kabeer Muhammad Shai of the National Party were also present, but escaped unhurt.

Speaking in the NA, Maulana

PTI boycotts NA, backs Sept 8 strike: Page 3

Abdul Ghafoor Haideri of the JUI-F said that since he was a child, he had been witnessing "military operations" in the province. He alleged that the government was not ready to pay heed to the genuine grievances of the people of Balochistan, and was unable to satisfy the family members of the missing persons.

"Instead of stopping the [military] operations, lawlessness and cruelty, the rulers are unfortunately sprinkling salt on the wounds of the people," said Mr Haideri while referring to a reported statement of Interior Minister Mohsin Naqvi in which he had stated that the Balochistan issue could be handled even by a police official of the rank of station house officer (SHO).

The JUI-F leader cited a number of

recent terror attacks in the province, including the one on his own convoy, claiming that over 1,000 people and security personnel had so far lost their lives in these incidents. He asked the government to convene an all parties' conference on the Balochistan issue.

The JUI-F lawmaker regretted that some 40 relatives, mostly woman and children, had been staging a protest sit-in outside the press club in Islamabad, but the government had not sent any delegation or team to hear their grievances. Instead, he regretted, the authorities were bent upon declaring them "traitors".

"How can you call these people traitors and rebels when they have been sitting in the capital right under the nose of the parliament and the judiciary" requesting the government to tell them the whereabouts of their missing family members.

Another JUI-F MNA Usman Badini in his speech hit out at the opposition PTI over the party's alleged silence on the issues of Balochistan.

"On one hand, the PTI people are making Mehmood Khan Achakzai their head and on the other hand, they are not ready to talk about the suicide attack in Balochistan," he said.

Responding to the speeches of Balochistan MNAs, State Minister for Interior Talal Chaudhry reaffirmed the government's readiness to engage with Balochistan's leadership and

Continued on Page 5

Pakistan seeks joint action against Afghanistan-based terror groups

Page 1

• FO rejects Taliban minister's criticism, defends border operations • Says no pause in expulsion of Afghans after deadly earthquake • Spox avoids addressing Trump's remarks, says SCO promotes multilateralism, peace

By Baqir Sajjad Syed

ISLAMABAD: Pakistan on Friday emphasised the seriousness of the threat posed to regional peace and stability by Afghanistan-based terrorist groups, calling it a common challenge that required collaborative efforts.

"Groups like Fitna Al-Khwarij represent a common threat to the peace and stability of our region, necessitating collective action to counter their malign influence," Foreign Office spokesman Shafqat Ali Khan said at a weekly media briefing.

The government uses the term to refer to the banned Tehreek-i-Taliban Pakistan (TTP) terrorist group.

The spokesman was responding to questions about reported Pakistani strikes across the border and com-

ments by Taliban acting Defence Minister Mullah Yaqoob, who accused Pakistan of blaming Afghanistan for its own security shortcomings.

Pakistan has long maintained that it faces a persistent threat from militant groups operating out of Afghanistan, including the TTP and the Balochistan Liberation Army (BLA). Multiple United Nations Security Council reports have noted the presence of sanctuaries for these groups in Afghanistan, which Islamabad says enable cross-border attacks.

Taliban officials, however, deny the allegations. In a recent media interview, Mullah Yaqoob said Pakistan's security apparatus was to blame for failing to prevent militant infiltrations.

"If they cross into Pakistan from Afghanistan and travel deep inside

Pakistani territory, why aren't they stopped there? Instead of addressing this, Pakistan unjustly accuses Afghanistan," he said.

Shafqat Ali dismissed the Taliban defence chief's remarks as "an exercise in irony". "It cannot mask the seriousness of this issue," he said, adding: "The enormity of the matter cannot be diminished by whatever number of statements you issue."

The FO spokesman said security forces and law enforcement agencies conduct "targeted operations in border regions to safeguard our citizens from terrorist threats".

"These operations are meticulously planned based on credible and actionable intelligence and executed with precision," he said, adding that

Continued on Page 8

Rivers calmer, but more rain could derail relief work

- No further breaches planned as major surge crosses Multan, Muzaffargarh without incident
- High alert along Sutlej as official warns of more flows from India
- PDMA estimates over 3m people displaced; minister announces Rs2m compensation for families of the slain
- PM orders climate change ministry to start preparing for next monsoon

By Imran Gabol

LAHORE: Although a major surge, exceeding 600,000 cusecs in the River Chenab, has crossed Multan and Muzaffargarh without incident, the threat from surging waters has not yet subsided, as more rains are expected to disrupt rescue and rehabilitation work, and bring more water to Punjab's already swollen rivers.

A major wave crossed the Head Muhammadwala and Sher Shah Bridges and is now advancing towards Panjnad Headworks, where it is expected to peak at 600,000 cusecs by tonight (Saturday), a senior irrigation department official told Dawn.

The episode reveals the complex interplay of Punjab's river systems. In the River Ravi, water levels at Sidhnai Headworks only began receding after the flood pressure in the Chenab subsided near their convergence point at Abdul Hakeem.

For a tense 36 hours, Sidhnai faced one of its most severe tests as the extremely high flood in the Chenab created a virtual wall of water, blocking the Ravi's flow and causing it to flow backward,

dramatically increasing pressure on the headworks.

To avert a disaster, the government was forced to carry out a strategic breach at the Mai Safura embankment three days ago to relieve this pressure.

The river flow report released by PDMA Punjab shows that while overall water levels are high, but flows have generally stabilised.

More coverage on Page 2

Multan Deputy Commissioner Wasim Hamid Sindhu said that the intensity of floodwaters in the Chenab was decreasing.

He said that water levels reaching Head Muhammad Wala Bridge, Basti Jhagunwala, Akbar embankment, Sikanderi Nallah and Sher Shah were decreasing and the reading on the emergency gate at Akbar embankment had fallen from 414 to 413.5.

He said that the water level in the Chenab was expected to decrease over the next 12 hours, adding that Head Muhammad Wala or the Sher

Continued on Page 5

Page 1



MULTAN: An elderly woman makes her bed next to an elevated road, after her locality — seen in the background — was submerged by floodwaters from the Chenab.—APP

Bilawal sees 'agriculture emergency' in Punjab

Page 1

• Seeks loan, electricity bill waivers for flood-hit farmers • Says PM has assured him of help for affected people • Accuses India of violating Indus treaty by withholding flood data

By Afzal Ansari

KASUR: As floods continue to batter Punjab and severely impact farmers, PPP Chairman Bilawal Bhutto-Zardari on Thursday urged both the federal and provincial governments to declare an agricultural emergency in the province.

The PPP leader visited the flood-hit Talwar Post in Kasur, on the border with India, met affected families and later spoke to the media.

According to statement, Mr Bhutto-Zardari also telephoned Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif and briefed him on the problems being faced by farmers across Punjab.

He told the premier that the floods had caused severe damage to the agriculture sector and said the Centre must play its role in helping farmers.

According to a readout of the call issued by the PPP, PM Shehbaz assured Mr Bhutto-Zardari that the government would take all possible steps to help the disaster-stricken farmers of Punjab.

The PPP leader also demanded that electricity bills of farmers in disaster-hit districts be waived, while the repayment of agricultural loans should either be delayed or written off.

He also proposed cash transfers to the affected farmers through the Benazir Income Support Programme (BISP), as was done in the wake of previous floods.

In the aftermath of the catastrophic floods in 2010 and 2011, the government had partnered with international donors to roll out cash grant programmes through the Watan Card and Pakistan Card schemes.

Their success was eventually

Continued on Page 5

Shabana becomes home minister in UK cabinet shakeup

Page 1

• Starmer reshuffles portfolios after his embattled deputy Rayner steps down over property tax scandal • David Lammy named new deputy PM; Yvette Cooper moves to Foreign Office • Ex-Columbia University president Shafik named PM's chief economic adviser

By Our Correspondent

LONDON: Faced by crises on multiple fronts, UK PM Keir Starmer overhauled his cabinet on Friday, picking David Lammy to replace his embattled deputy PM, and bringing in Shabana Mahmood to head the Home Office.

Former deputy PM Angela Rayner quit after an investigation found that she had breached the ministerial code, underpaying a property tax in the purchase of a flat in southern England.

Her departure prompted Starmer to carry out the first major cabinet reshuffle of his stuttering 14-month-old premiership.

The shake-up comes after



SHABANA Mahmood

Rayner's resignation dealt the latest blow to Starmer's flagging government that has lurched from one storm to another since he became prime minister in July last year.



ANGELA Rayner

It has been forced to U-turn on welfare reforms and fuel benefits for the elderly, while its failure to stop undocumented migrants arriving on small boats has bolstered sup-

port for Reform, led by anti-immigrant firebrand Nigel Farage.

Lammy's post as Britain's top diplomat will be taken by Home Secretary Yvette Cooper, who will in turn be succeeded by Ms Mahmood, the *BBC* reported.

This means that for the first time, all three of the most senior and historically important cabinet positions will be held by women, as Rachel Reeves is the current chancellor of the Exchequer.

Others leaving key posts include leader of the House of Commons Lucy Powell and Secretary of State for Scotland Ian Murray.

Meanwhile, economist Nemat Talaat Shafik has been named Starmer's new chief

economic adviser.

Baroness Shafik was previously the president of Columbia University, and was pushed out following fallout from the 2024 Gaza protests. She has also served as a deputy governor at the Bank of England.

Rayner's troubles

Rayner's resignation followed her self-referral to the independent adviser on ministerial standards.

She disclosed on Wednesday that she had underpaid stamp duty – a property tax – on an apartment following days of reports suggesting that she had saved thousands of pounds by removing her name from the deeds of another property.

After reviewing her case,

Laurie Magnus wrote to the PM, saying that in his opinion, she had breached the ministerial code.

He pointed out that while the tax rules Rayner was dealing with are “complex”, the fact that she didn't seek expert advice means that she did not meet the “highest possible standards of proper conduct”, as required by the Ministerial Code.

In her resignation, Rayner took full responsibility for the error. In response, Starmer said she had done the right thing.

Rayner had been tipped as a potential future Labour leader and has been a top target for political attacks by the

Continued on Page 5

Body to conduct survey of affected areas for rehab package

By Our Staff Reporter

LAHORE: The Punjab government has formed a high-level committee to conduct a survey of the flood-affected areas before announcing a compensation and rehabilitation package.

Chief Minister Maryam Nawaz on Friday held a meeting to deliberate a comprehensive package for the flood victims.

She directed the Urban Unit, Board of Revenue and other relevant departments to take steps in this regard by considering problems of the victims.

She formed a high-level committee to conduct a survey of the affected areas before preparing an 'effective' rehabilitation package, and directed the relevant authorities to complete the survey as soon as possible by employing a transparent procedure, including digital recording.

The CM also directed them to increase relief funds in the rehabilitation package, besides devising a rehabilitation programme for the farmers.

She said she would announce a rehabilitation package for the flood victims. She directed the authorities concerned to set up marquees in every district for the displaced families who would not be able to return immediately due to destruction of their homes.

"Flood-affected families will be shifted to marquees in every district in view of the arrival of winter."

She directed to remove encroachments and settlements from waterways. She also directed to include 'Apni Chhat, Apna Ghar' programme in the package for the rehabilitation of flood victims.

Floods suspended train operations on five sections in Punjab

By Khalid Hasnain

LAHORE: The train operations on five rail sections in Punjab have to be suspended because of the damage caused to the railway track and other infrastructure by the continuing floods and rains in the province.

Due to the heavy rains and floods, which also disrupted the train operations for a short time across the country, the power distribution companies (Discos), including the Lahore Electric Supply Company (Lesco) and Gujranwala Electric Power Company (Gepco) also faced a massive loss of electricity supply infrastructure, Dawn has learnt.

According to an internal report compiled by the Pakistan Railways (PR) and shared with *Dawn*, the Narowal-Sialkot section has been closed since Aug 27 after the floodwater breached a portion of the track. Moreover, a Girder Span of bridge No 7 near Aik Nullah misaligned, allowing floodwater to maintain a high level, overtopping the track.

The report says that the repair works are underway on the damaged section, which is expected to be ready for resump-

tion of the train operation by Sept 12.

The report mentions that the Chak Jhumra-Shaheenabad (Sargodha) section was also temporarily closed for the rail traffic on the night of Aug 29, while an exceptionally high flood damaged bridge No 132 & 134 near Chiniot. The efforts are underway to repair/reconstruct the bridge to restore the train operation on this section, it adds.

Similarly, it says, the Wazirabad-Sialkot section has also closed since Sept 3 due to flooding and rain, allowing water to overtop the track between the Wazirabad-Sodhra Kopra section. Allama Iqbal Express also faced detention for two hours due to flooding. The Jhang-Shaheenabad section has also been closed following flooding in the area since Aug 28, after the flood caused breaching near Rivaz Railway Bridge over the river Chanab. The floodwater is still passing through the breached section, as the train traffic remains suspended.

The report further says that the Khanewal-Shorkot section is also closed since Sept 3, as the rail traffic was put on hold on this section due to high flood levels at Abdul Hakim Bridge No 27 at Railway km 36/10-14 and due to breaches at KM. 41/13-14, 42/13-14 & 43/01 on Sept

4 between Abdul Hakim-Darkana stations.

The flood situation has also caused temporary disruptions in the train operations at the Shahdra-Faisalabad section due to the cutting of an embankment at bridge No 10 last month. The trains are passing through this section with a restricted speed limit.

The report says that at the Lahore-Badami Bagh section, a tree fell on the track, causing the detention of Tezgam Express for 50 minutes, last month. The rail traffic also faced disruption at the Uggoki-Sialkot section last month after the floodwater overtopped the track by 12 inches, resulting in a 2-hour and 20-minute detention of the Sialkot Express.

At the Port Qasim-Bin Qasim rail section, the track faced blockage of trains for 12 hours due to a breach on both sides on Aug 20. The Kotri-Dadu section also remained blocked for three hours on Aug 20 due to boulder and mud sliding, the report adds.

It says that the Tando Adam-Hyderabad section also remained closed for freight train operations due to the accumulation of water in the Hyderabad yard for 15 hours on August 22. Likewise, the Peshawar Saddar-Cant section also

remained closed for around two hours due to urban flooding in Peshawar on Aug 18.

Meanwhile, Lesco is also facing damage to its supply system in various parts of its jurisdiction, which comprises Lahore, Kasur, Nankana, Okara and Sheikhupura districts.

Due to the floods, as many as 67 11kV feeders were affected. Of these, 55 have been re-energised. "As many as 73,724 consumers suffered power disruptions, and of them, 13,073 are still without electricity. In Kasur and Okara, precious material (cables) and power infrastructure were affected by the floods, whereas Lahore's various parts also faced issues.

"The floods have affected our infrastructure. But our teams worked day and night to restore power supply to the flood-affected areas. Still, 17 per cent of the total 73,724 consumers are affected," Lesco Chief Executive Officer Ramzan Butt said in a statement.

There are also reports of massive losses in the areas of Gepco, Multan Electric Power Company (Mepco) and Faisalabad Electric Supply Company (Fesco).

"In Bajwar, a rural area of Sialkot, the residents of 85 villages are without electricity since Aug 26," an official told *Dawn* from Sialkot on the phone.

Ravi flood destroys Sahiwal's road network

Page 2

SAHIWAL: Heavy flooding from the Ravi River has caused extensive damage to Sahiwal's road infrastructure, cutting off connections to several districts and communities.

Three main roads linking Sahiwal with Toba Tek Singh, Kamalia, Faisalabad, Gojra, Arifwala, Burewala, Vehari, Khanewal and Pakpattan have been completely washed away at multiple points with breaches exceeding 200 feet. Additionally, six smaller roads in villages are now impassable. They include the road from Murad Kay Katiya to Chak 18B/7-R, Kachi Pakki to Jhangi Sial, Kachi Pakki to Mauza Sial,

Chandini Chowk to Chichawatni, Purani Chichawatni to Chak 119/7 D-R and Kachi Paki to Chak 104/7-R. The damage isn't just to the road surface, approximately 100 culverts (known as *pulli*) have been destroyed and floodwater has eroded the ground beneath the roads in some areas.

This has halted all light and heavy traffic among the five affected districts for the past three days and dozens of villages in the area got disconnected. As a result, thousands of commuters and commercial vehicles are stranded, leading to a shortage of produce in the local vegetable market as supplies from Faisalabad and Toba

Tek Singh can't get through to Chichawatni.

Cattle traders are also struggling to bring livestock to the Chichawatni market, which is now serving as a shelter for flood-affected animals. Despite a recent drop in the Ravi's water level to 123,000 cusecs, the Flood Forecasting Division, Lahore, has warned of a new surge of 150,000 cusecs expected to reach Sahiwal tonight due to heavy rains in upstream districts of Punjab.

The local administration is on high alert. Muhammad Ramzan, executive engineer (EXEN) of the highway department, explained that repairs to the inter-village roads can't begin until the flood-

water recedes. "In case tonight more water comes, the situation will get worse as the water has already submerged 80pc of roads."

He said the C&W department is trying to install a steel bridge to reconnect a 200 foot breach on the main Chichawatni-Kamalia road, hoping to restore limited traffic within 48 hours if the new flood surge doesn't cause more damage. However, residents fear that the incoming water would overwhelm the temporary structure. The department is still assessing the full extent of the damage to both major and minor road networks. — **Shafiq Butt**

PTI boycotts NA, backs Sept 8 strike

Page 3

ISLAMABAD: PTI on Friday once again boycotted the proceedings of the National Assembly (NA) and announced support for the Sept 8 shutter-down strike call given by Balochistan National Party (BNP) and Pakhtunkhwa Milli Awami Party (PkMAP) in Balochistan.

Following the boycott, the main opposition party held a 'people's assembly' outside the Parliament House and urged the judiciary to take up PTT's appeals against the passage of 26th Constitutional

Amendment. They termed the amendment "a tool to suppress and undermine the judiciary".

"The people's assembly backs shutter-down strike call of BNP chief Akhtar Mengal and PkMAP President Mehmood Achakzai to be observed on Sept 8 in Balochsitan," said a resolution passed by the gathering.

The resolution, presented by PTI Chairman Barrister Ali Gohar, rejected what it called "hybrid regime" and demanded lifting of curbs imp-

osed on judiciary so that it could hear appeals filed against 26th Constitutional Amendment.

It also demanded suspension of Afghan refugees' repatriation process in view of prevailing instability in neighbouring Afghanistan. The resolution further endorsed the recent speech of Supreme Court judge Justice Athar Minallah.

Former NA speaker Asad Qaisar said no people-friendly legislation was being carried out in the parliament.—Syed Irfan Raza

Sharp rise seen in Afghans' return after end of deadline

Page 3

UNHCR report reveals that as of Sept 4, around half a million refugees have returned

By Amin Ahmed

ISLAMABAD: The UN refugee agency has said that the expiry of Proof of Registration (PoR) cards grace period that ended on August 31, has triggered a sharp rise in the return of Afghans from Pakistan.

A situation report of the UNHCR released on Friday said that in August alone, returns increased by 254 per cent, while deportations rose by 191pc as compared to July,

coinciding with the start of the third phase of the 'Illegal Foreigners Repatriation Plan' (IFPR).

The report says 531,700 Afghans have returned from Pakistan, as of September 4.

Since April, more than 483,700 Afghans have returned from Pakistan to Afghanistan, including 145,200 in August alone, with some 55,000 making the journey in just the final four days of the month. The proportion of Proof of Registration (PoR) card holders among returnees has steadily increased, rising from 6 per cent in April to 21-23 per cent between May and July.

In August, this share grew sharply, with PoR cardholders accounting for 54pc (77,700 individuals) of all returns recorded to date, the UNHCR data shows.

Some 57,300 individuals have been arrested and detained since April, including PoR card holders. In August alone, some 9,000 arrests were recorded, compared to some 3,400 in July. The top three districts for arrest and detention are Chaghi (Balochistan), Islamabad and Pishin (Balochistan).

In Afghanistan, the UNHCR continued to biometrically process and provide cash assistance to PoR card holders and their nuclear family members, UNHCR slip holders, asylum seeker certificate holders and other protection referrals. This support aimed at alleviating the difficulties faced by Afghans who have returned home hastily, and often largely unprepared due to the circumstances in Pakistan, the report says.

Homage to armed forces, martyrs

Page 3

President, PM recall 1965 war, praise recent Operation Bunyanum Marsoos; call Sept 6 a 'glorious chapter'

ISLAMABAD: President Asif Ali Zardari and Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif paid rich tribute to the valiant sacrifices of Pakistan's armed forces and martyrs on the eve of Defence Day, reaffirming the nation's unwavering commitment to safeguarding its sovereignty, countering modern threats, and building a united, prosperous future.

In separate messages ahead of Sept 6, the two leaders reaffirmed the nation's commitment to safeguarding sovereignty, countering external threats, and building a united, prosperous future.

They also recalled the 1965 war with India, noting that Pakistan's valiant armed forces, with the full

support of the people, had thwarted enemy aggression, proving that the country possesses the will and capacity to defend its independence and integrity.

Highlighting the recent Operation Bunyanum Marsoos, Marka-i-Haq, PM Shehbaz lauded the Pakistan Army, Navy, and Air Force for their unmatched professionalism and combat skills under the strategic leadership of Chief of Army Staff Gen Syed Asim Munir.

He reaffirmed Pakistan's commitment to peace and constructive international engagement but warned against ignoring the reality of continuous Indian provocations and shifting regional dynamics.

Expressing solidarity with the oppressed people of occupied Jammu and Kashmir, the prime minister reiterated unwavering support for their struggle for self-determination, stressing that it cannot be suppressed by force.

He also strongly condemned ongoing Israeli aggression in Palestine and urged the interna-

tional community to ensure the protection of civilians and uninterrupted humanitarian aid to Gaza.

'Glorious chapter'

Meanwhile, President Asif Ali Zardari, in his message, paid tribute to the valiant sacrifices of the nation's armed forces and reaffirmed Pakistan's unwavering commitment to its defence and sovereignty.

He described September 6 as a glorious chapter in the country's history. He emphasised that the spirit of sacrifice from the 1965 war continues to serve as a guiding light for future generations.

The president highlighted the significance of this year's Defence Day in light of the recent Operation Bunyanum Marsoos conducted in May 2025 against India.

"Just as our courageous forces demonstrated extraordinary valor and dedication in 1965, our sons once again proved their unmatched bravery during this year's operation," he said.—APP

Justice Shah nails his grievances at SC door

Page 3

Continued from Page 1

undiscussed.

This is the second such letter by Justice Shah in less than a month, who, along with Justice Munib Akhtar, had on Aug 20 regretted that challenges to the 26th Amendment continue to remain pending and a golden opportunity to decide them at the earliest instance before the institution as a whole — i.e. the full court has been lost, perhaps irretrievably.

In the letter, Justice Shah noted that the legitimacy of the CJP's office and the Supreme Court hung in the balance due to pending challenges to the 26th Amendment.

These petitions remain unheard for nearly a year, he said, emphasising that the petitions must be heard by the original full court, excluding judges elevated after the amendment. Until then, any initiative under CJP's leadership remains institutionally fragile, for its foundation was constitutionally suspect.

Justice Shah also emphasised that his letter should not be mis-

taken for personal grievance, rather it was written from a position of credibility and responsibility, as he had decided the largest number of cases — 3,956 — and authored 35 reported judgements during the CJP's tenure.

In the fresh letter, Justice Shah also asked why a meeting of the three-judge committee formed under the Practice and Procedure Act-2023 and comprising the Chief Justice of Pakistan, Justice Akhtar and himself was never convened to carry out its statutory responsibilities.

On Friday, Justice Shah regretted that not a single official meeting of three-member committee had been convened since the Chief Justice of Pakistan assumed office in October 2024.

He also pointed out that bench formation was carried out and cause lists issued "unilaterally" without the committee's deliberations. Rosters are circulated for signatures, expecting members to endorse them blindly without discussion of case allocation or categorisation, a direct violation of the act

raising serious concern, Justice Shah wrote.

He also questioned why junior judges were regularly assigned to three-member benches, while senior judges were confined to two-judge benches, and why issues of national importance with far-reaching policy implications were not fixed before senior benches.

Justice Shah, however, expressed his confidence that the Chief Justice of Pakistan would use the judicial conference (the full court meeting scheduled for Sept 8) as a moment of institutional renewal by answering the questions being asked and reaffirming the principles of collegiality and constitutional fidelity.

Expressing surprise at a general standing order (GSO) on judges' leaves, Justice Shah wrote that leave was recognised as an "entitlement, not a favour".

Similarly, he said, the recent policy on releasing dissenting opinions alongside majority judgements was approved through a unique process of soliciting views of individual judges by the registrar.

Rivers calmer, but more rain

Page 4

Continued from Page 1

Shah embankment would not be breached.

Threat from impending rain

Addressing a press conference in Gujranwala, Provincial Disaster Management Authority (PDMA) Director General Irfan Ali Kathia said that another incoming rain spell was expected to disrupt ongoing rescue operations across flood-affected regions. He said that after yet another high-flood warning from India at the Harike location, the government had placed all districts along the Sutlej River on high alert.

DG Kathia warned that fresh rainfall would create additional difficulties for those already affected by the floods.

The National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA) has already warned officials in Punjab, Sindh and Islamabad to remain alert for a spell forecast from Sept 7-9. According to the NDMA, a low-pressure system is currently located over Madhya Pradesh (India) and likely to move west-northwest, may reach Rajasthan and adjoining parts of Sindh today. Under the influence of this weather system, Punjab, Sindh and Islamabad may face heavy to very heavy rains.

Damages

Speaking at the tail-end of the National Assembly sitting on Friday, Law Minister Azam Nazeer Tarar said that so far, 2.1 million people had been displaced by the floods.

He termed it a massive disaster that was not easy to cope with, adding that meteorological predictions had been correct with a 92pc accuracy rate.

He revealed that the families of those who lost their lives due to the floods would

be given Rs2m in compensation, adding that Rs680m had been paid to families of those killed and injured so far.

Separately, PDMA Punjab issued a report on damages caused by flooding in Ravi, Sutlej, and Chenab rivers, which stated that over 3,900 villages had been affected. The report put the figure of those affected by the floods at 3.89m.

Around 1.84m people trapped in floodwaters have been relocated to safety, while 1.34m animals had been relocated.

According to Punjab Relief Commissioner Nabil Javaid, the reservoirs at Mangla and Tarbela are at 87pc and 100pc capacity, respectively. Meanwhile, India's Bhakra Dam on the Sutlej River is at 84pc, the Pong Dam is at 98pc, while the Thein Dam is 92pc full.

PM orders prep for next monsoon

Separately, chairing a high-level review meeting to assess the damage, as well as the ongoing rescue, relief, and rehabilitation efforts underway across the country, PM Shehbaz Sharif ordered the Ministry of Climate Change to begin immediate preparations for the 2026 monsoon season and present a comprehensive climate resilience action plan within two weeks.

The plan, he said, must address Pakistans growing vulnerability to climate change. The PM stressed the need for real-time monitoring of evacuation and relief operations to ensure that timely assistance reaches those in need. He instructed the establishment of a special committee to facilitate financial assistance for flood victims who are not currently registered with Nadra.

The meeting was informed that compensation for deceased persons, the injured, and property damages was being processed through Nadra, with priority being given to those most affected.



PPP Chairman Bilawal Bhutto-Zardari meets flood-hit farmers in Kasur.—Dawn

Bilawal sees 'agriculture emergency' in Punjab

Continued from Page 1

replicated with the BISP programme, which has since won international acclaim for its effectiveness in augmenting poverty alleviation efforts.

In Kasur, the PPP chairman heard the grievances of farmers and stressed that the federal and provincial governments should work together to provide relief to the affected people.

The PPP will stand with the provincial government during the relief and reconstruction phases, he said, adding that no single government can cope with a calamity of this scale. Speaking at Talwar Post, Mr Bhutto-Zardari accused India of violating the Indus Waters Treaty (IWT) and withholding flood-related information from Pakistan.

He said that in doing so, India had for-

gotten basic humanity.

Mr Bhutto-Zardari praised Punjab Chief Minister Maryam Nawaz for making efforts to provide relief to people displaced by the floods, and stressed the need to stand shoulder to shoulder with farmers.

The PPP chairman also directed his party workers to take an active part in relief activities and assured the affected families that his party would not abandon them.

Mr Bhutto-Zardari was received by senior PPP leader Chaudhry Manzoor Ahmed during his visit to Kasur. The PPP chairman was accompanied by Punjab Governor Sardar Saleem Haider, former National Assembly speaker Raja Pervaiz Ashraf, Hasan Murtaza, Nadeem Afzal Chan and Qamar Zaman Kaira.

Two security personnel martyred in Kech

Page 4

By Behram Baloch

GWADAR: Two security personnel were martyred in an armed attack on Friday in the Mand area of Kech district, near the Iranian border.

According to officials, the attack took place in Koh-Pushat Bazar, where the armed assailants ambushed the security personnel on a motorbike,

opening fire and killing them on the spot.

Levy forces and other security personnel responded quickly, securing the area and transporting the victims' bodies to a nearby medical facility.

The slain individuals were identified as Abdul Aziz and Jameel Ahmed, who were reportedly in plain clothes at the time of the attack.

UK cabinet shakeup

Page 4

Continued from Page 1

opposition Conservatives and right-wing media.

Despite the circumstances of her exit, Starmer told her: "You will remain a major figure in our party".

Shabana's rise

Shabana Mahmood, the 44-year-old Labour MP for Birmingham Ladywood, has had a rapid rise. She becomes the second Home Secretary of Pakistani-origin, with Tory minister Sajid Javid being the first in 2018.

Born in Birmingham to parents with roots in Mirpur in Azad Kashmir, Mahmood often links her political outlook to her family's migration story and the values she absorbed growing up around a corner shop in inner-city Birmingham.

In a *New Statesman* interview, she linked her parents' politics to the party "that made them feel they had a stake in British society," adding that her family "found opportunities in this country that would not have been available to us in the village that we hail from in Kashmir and then Pakistan."

During her childhood she also lived for a period with her family in Taif, Saudi Arabia. She went on to study at the University of Oxford and graduated with a BA in Law, later working as a barrister.

Mahmood also became one of the UK's first Muslim parliamentarians when she was elected in 2010 alongside other MPs.

She has spoken directly about representing Britain's Pakistani communities. "I...take pride in representing one of the biggest ethnic minority groups in the UK," she told the British Pakistan Foundation in an interview, arguing that the government should work at the community levels.

She also rejected claims that Pakistanis do not hold British values, saying: "They respect the rule of law, they want to live in a democracy."

Balochistan situation takes priority

Page 4

Continued from Page 1

political representatives to find practical solutions to the province's issues.

About the ongoing protest outside the NPC in Islamabad, the minister said the authorities had been providing security and necessary facilitation to them despite the fact that they had been staging protest on a road inside the Red Zone. He claimed that the government as

well as the district administration officials had been in continuous contact with the protesters, and "trying to address their concerns through proper channels."

He alleged that some individuals were exploiting the ongoing protest for their personal gains or political point-scoring.

The minister informed the house that nearly 2,000 missing person cases had been registered

and the relevant commission had been monitoring these matters according to rules.

Interestingly, the minister indirectly put the blame of the Quetta blast on the organisers of the public meeting, stating that holding political gatherings without proper clearance created soft targets.

PTI's walkout

At the outset of the sitting, PTI Chairman Gohar Ali Khan regretted that the National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA) was not helping the flood-affected people in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa.

Mr Khan announced that the PTI members had decided to boycott the NA sitting, stating they could not be a part of the "unconstitutional proceedings".

The PTI members staged a walkout from the assembly after making a failed attempt to disrupt the proceedings by pointing out quorum.

Speaker Ayaz Sadiq declared the house in order following a headcount and continued proceedings without the PTI members.

The speaker castigated them for boycotting the NDMA briefing and offered them that he could arrange a separate briefing of the NDMA officials for the PTI members.

He said after staging a walkout from the house, the PTI members would now tell the press outside the Parliament House that they were not being given opportunity to speak. The PTI members held a "public assembly session" outside the Parliament House.

The NA session, which began on Monday, has been prorogued for an indefinite period.

Hybrid failures

Page 5

IT is difficult to disagree with the remarks of the Supreme Court's Justice Athar Minallah, who on Thursday indicated that the hybrid system in Pakistan — where unelected powers are actively involved in civilian affairs — is a euphemism for dictatorship. The veteran judge, while speaking in Karachi, also dwelt on the role the senior judiciary has played in the country's history by endorsing the unconstitutional moves of strongmen. Putting it bluntly, he said that the "77-year judicial history is not a matter of pride for me", while giving examples of the Maulvi Tamizuddin case, as well as of Zulfikar Ali Bhutto's trial and Gen Musharraf's assaults on the constitutional order, to prove how at crucial times their lordships have sided with authoritarian rulers to subvert the rule of law. Mr Minallah also praised the bravery of judges who refused to bow before dictators.

Pakistan's damaging experiments with different forms of hybridity, from earlier decades to the present day, have only weakened institutions, particularly parliament and the judiciary. And rarely have proponents of the hybrid system been held to account for their failures; the actual powers wash their hands of mistakes, while their civilian partners face the music. In contrast, in fully functioning democratic systems, elected leaders are held accountable before the voter. Considering the judiciary's role, as highlighted by Justice Minallah, in supporting unconstitutional moves — and these grim episodes are well-documented in our history — 'willing' collaborators on the bench have worked with usurpers to subvert the constitutional system, often guided by the 'doctrine of necessity'. Sadly, in the current scenario too, many of their lordships have been perceived as coming to the aid of the real powers to give their legal blessings to doubtful laws and amendments.

The solution, as Justice Minallah suggested, is deceptively simple on paper, but difficult to put into practice: abiding by the Constitution, with all institutions staying within the bounds prescribed for them by the basic law. In this regard, when the country faces rampant insecurity, it is essential that the military sticks to its core duty of defending Pakistan. We face two major militant insurgencies — in KP and Balochistan — while a hostile neighbour to the east, and an unreliable regime in Kabul, mean we must constantly remain vigilant. In such a situation, if the security apparatus indulges in political management, the focus on defence can become diluted. Whether it is direct military rule or a 'hybrid' system, both have left lasting scars on the constitutional system. Hence, there is a need to move away from the hybrid model in the interest of democracy, and in the interests of both the civilian and military leaderships.

Tricky regulation

Page 5

MEMBERS of the Senate Standing Committee on Finance and Revenue recommended last Wednesday that all those associated with the Pakistan Virtual Asset Regulatory Authority be barred from trading in virtual assets. Their concern for integrity is commendable and certainly not misplaced, but the trouble is, how effectively could such a bar be enforced? The markets for virtual assets have always been opaque, with buyers and sellers difficult to track or trace. That is why they have been used so extensively by shady operators and those looking to move value across economic borders undetected. It is not without reason that the finance minister, who heads the Pakistan Crypto Council, still does not seem entirely accepting of the idea of rushing into the space. Perhaps the honourable members of the committee ought to have spent more time reflecting on these facets instead of bickering over who should get credit for the PVARA bill. Indeed, PVARA is supposed to prevent such practices — it is mandated to ensure transparency, compliance and prevent illicit activities such as money laundering and terrorism financing — but without sufficient regulatory guidelines first being devised and implemented, rules like these will always be difficult to enforce.

And that still seems to be the albatross around the government's neck. It has yet to come up with a comprehensive regulatory system with which to tether the crypto beast. To be clear, this was never an easy undertaking: most financial jurisdictions around the world remain extremely wary of crypto assets, and there are only a handful of countries that have ventured to embrace them. But given the fanfare around Pakistan's 'great leap' towards crypto, one had expected much more progress on this undertaking than has been visible up to this point. It should be highlighted that virtual asset markets have evolved very quickly and continue to do so. It is essential, therefore, for a country entering them formally to be very versatile in its approach. The regulatory bodies that Pakistan wishes to create must not only be ethical and capable, but also agile and able to adapt to emerging technologies, new market entrants — and threats. If the authorities continue to deliberate at the pace they have so far, they will always remain behind the curve. They must decide what it is they wish to accomplish and whether it is worth the risk.

HPV vaccine

Page 5

BY and large, it is the low-income countries that face the greatest burden of disease. Several factors contribute to this sobering reality including poor access to healthcare and inadequate resources. Which is why regular vaccine campaigns, undertaken to prevent the onset of many of the illnesses seen mostly in developing nations, are absolutely crucial in a country like ours. In this context, the planned addition of a new vaccine to the Expanded Programme on Immunisation is a welcome development. The campaign for the phased rollout of the human papillomavirus vaccine to prevent cervical cancer is set to begin on Sept 15. In Sindh, the aim is to immunise 4.1m girls from nine to 14 years against the virus — although once incorporated fully in the EPI, the focus will shift to nine-year-olds and hopefully become part of a school-outreach programme. The campaign will be rolled out in Punjab, ICT and AJK at the same time; in KP in 2026; and in Balochistan and GB in 2027.

Without regular screening cervical cancer can go undetected in females, especially as symptoms may be absent in the early stages. And in a country like Pakistan, where routine pelvic examinations are not actively recommended, negligence can cost lives. Around 5,000 women in the country are diagnosed with cervical cancer each year; 60pc of them succumb to the disease. And these are only the numbers recorded. It is safe to assume that the actual number of cases for this cancer — the second most common one among women of child-bearing age — is far higher. By including the vaccine in the EPI, then, it is hoped that awareness levels are heightened — perhaps, the mothers of the young girls that the HPV vaccine will target under the EPI will learn enough about the risks of cervical cancer to take precautionary steps themselves through inoculation or regular screening. It appears to be a goal worth pursuing.

Trump stung by SCO optics



THE Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) summit in Tianjing, followed by the grand military parade in Beijing's Tiananmen Square, was all about optics and signaling. Looking at the reaction from the US and EU it would be safe to say that the messages hit bull's eye.

But let's first look closer to home. Before the summit, India's Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri said India would be looking for a categorical condemnation of cross-border terrorism, which in common language means that India's allegations against Pakistan are upheld.

You may recall in this column last week, there was a mention of the SCO principle of collective or indivisible security and once again that was upheld as both the Pahalgam terror incident and the Jaffar Express and the Khuzdar school bus terror attacks, in which many innocent lives were lost — with India blaming Pakistan for the first and Pakistan saying India was responsible for the second and third incidents — were condemned but neither country was named.

Despite lack of success on this issue, as in the SCO foreign ministers meeting in June, Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi was triumphantly holding hands with Russian President Vladimir Putin and laughing in videos captured of their stand-up chats with China's strongman Xi Jinping.

Knowledgeable sources suggested Mr Modi was keen to thumb his nose at the US and its 'unreliable' leader and his erstwhile friend President Donald J. Trump whom he has courted in the past, even raising the slogan, ahead of the US elections: *Abki baar, Trump Sarkar* (The next administration will be Trump's).

India is smarting at the 'unfair' 25+25 per cent tariffs with the latter being punitive for continued purchases of Russian oil when China and many other countries have not been penalised for their bulk oil/energy procurement from Russia. But the size of the rapidly growing Indian economy, its human capital and enormous market means that despite its current tribulations, India won't be ignored by either the US and its allies or the Global South for long. That is a certainty.

Moving out of the region into the global arena, it was clear that the summit and the parade signalled what China sees as a return to a multipolar

world and not the unipolar arrangement that evolved after the collapse of the Soviet Union and facilitated the massive eastward expansion of the Nato military alliance.

The Russian military assault and the war it triggered in Ukraine are attributed to that unipolar world, which meant initially that Moscow lacked the ability to stop the Western military alliance's eastwards march. Later, however, after internal consolidation Russia started to flex its muscles first in Crimea and then in the Donbas region and made rapid advances in eastern Ukraine to pre-empt Nato's further expansion.

China may still not be militarily as strong as the US but it seems to be catching up fast.

President Joe Biden pumped billions of dollars into the ideological military campaign directly and via the Nato members and slowed the pace of the Russian advance. With Trump's assumption of office, all that changed as the new US president announced he wanted to end the war and that his friend Vladimir Putin was on board. So far it appears he got played by the Russian leader.

It was not surprising then that looking at the SCO summit and the grand spectacle put on display by the People's Liberation Army in Beijing to mark the 80th anniversary of the Chinese victory over the Japanese military, Trump wrote a congratulatory message on his Truth Social platform and then said words that could be likened to a child throwing his toys out of the pram: "Give my warmest regards to Vladimir Putin, and Kim Jong Un, as you conspire against The United States of America."

China's response was measured as its spokesperson underlined the fact that the commemoration was to mark the end to World War II and that foreign guests had been invited for it. China said

its development of diplomatic relations with any country is never directed against a third party.

Trump's political appointee as ambassador to Nato Matthew Whitaker seemed to have lost it in an interview with Fox News when, in a fit of rage, he accused China of putting on display lethal weaponry "in all likelihood stolen from us".

EU foreign policy chief, the former right-wing Estonian politician, Kaja Kallas also criticised the parade and said that Xi, Putin and Kim appearing together was part of efforts to build an anti-Western "new world order" and was a direct challenge to the international rules-based system.

China described the remarks by a "certain EU official" as being full of ideological bias, lacking basic historical knowledge and a blatant attempt to stir up confrontation. Beijing found the remarks misguided, utterly irresponsible and arrogant.

It was laughable that the hawkish EU foreign policy chief referred to the rules-based international system when she and her grouping has supported the Gaza genocide and the shredding of any so-called rules-based order by the apartheid state on a daily basis by the mass murder of civilians by bombs, missiles, drones and starvation.

To many an impartial observer, China's awesome military display translated into the introduction of a semblance of welcome balance in our unipolar world. China may still not be militarily as strong as the US but it seems to be catching up fast as its various arms and armaments including new hypersonic missiles, stealth fighter-bombers, lasers and microwave air defence and unmanned aerial and submarine military vehicles displayed.

One hopes this doesn't unhinge Trump completely. He should realise that his desire of winning the Nobel Peace Prize was nearly non-existent, because he greenlit and enabled the Gaza genocide, a grave crime against humanity. Equally, no end to the Ukraine war on terms unfavourable to Russia is now likely. Trump's threatened tariffs and sanctions can cause pain but not in any decisive way.

It will be interesting to watch the White House's next move. ■

The writer is a former editor of Dawn.
 abbas.nasir@hotmail.com



Unpacking campus scandals

Reports of sexual misconduct are weaponised to enforce segregation and oppose coeducation.

NO one denies that outrageous incidents occur within our universities, sometimes making national news. Examples include professors demanding sexual favours for better grades, male students creating fake, explicit AI images of female students, and administrators or low-level employees using hidden cameras for blackmail. Social media magnifies all this by a thousand, maybe a million. My internet search shows that some salacious on-sale videos can be viewed for only Rs100. Each scandal inevitably triggers public outrage that peaks and then fades.

Rightly speaking, university administrators should swiftly investigate and appropriately punish teachers or students. Unfortunately, this is rare. However, officials cannot always be held responsible because female students are usually too afraid to testify, fearing damage to their reputations even if they had been trapped and were guiltless. In a heavily patriarchal society with skewed power relationships, what can they do?

Media lynching — such as the recent sting operation at Bahawalpur University — is therefore seen as an alternative. Carried out by a popular TV channel, its viewership must have skyrocketed. The university's authorities had, as expected, waffled. But is justice truly served by cameras chasing some bad-guy professor? One can be doubtful.

True injustice occurs, however, when these instances are weaponised by reactionary voices. They rush to seize a megaphone, multiply fears, ignite lurid sexual fantasies and declare the coed university as a den of sin and temptation disallowed by religious and cultural mores. See, they say, let the sexes intermingle and *bay-hayaae* (immorality) is what you get.

The impact of such propaganda in a conservative society can only be imagined. In the aftermath of even a single incident, we cannot ever know how many hundreds of daughters were disallowed by their fathers or brothers from enrolling at some coed campus or being withdrawn from one.

A frequently proposed solution is to have more women-only universities. This is a dead end. I've guest lectured at several and to call them universities is a travesty. Perhaps they could be better described as female safe houses or custodial centres where minds must be sheltered and dulled,

not challenged and sharpened.

What about going the Taliban way, and banning female education altogether? Even with the explosive growth of Pakistani conservatism, the near parity of male-female enrolment (100-96) in tertiary education suggests that urbanites do not want this extreme. Universities — whose revenues depend on enrolment — tread cautiously.

As a way out, worried officials aim to reassure fathers and brothers (mothers rarely matter) by increasing segregation through strict moral policing. Official circulars are periodically issued that threaten violators with fines, denial of entry on campus, withholding of semester results, or expulsion. But how do they define morality?

Official websites do not list as 'immoral' crimes like theft, academic cheating, plagiarism or vandalism. Similarly, harassment and violence against different ethnic and religious groups, or disrupting cultural and music festivals, are not classified as immoral. Depending on who's in charge, some officials disallow such actions while others secretly or openly endorse them.

Immorality, however, revolves around female attire. While none can deny that clothing should be 'modest', its meaning varies from city to city and campus to campus. Back in the early 1970s, when I started my university teaching career, the number of female students at Quaid-e-Azam University in burqa were fewer than the fingers on one hand. Today they are the majority, followed by the less restrictive hijab, while those without head cover are outliers.

Morality also comes under threat when a female walks by herself (hence becomes vulnerable), engages in casual conversations with male students, or makes friends across the divide. This is less emphasised at institutions like Lums whose official policy merely forbids PDA (public display of affection) such as the holding of hands. But within that same city is Punjab University (PU), a once-decent relic from British times.

Now better known for hyperactive moral squads than for scholarly accomplishments, PU is the headquarters of the Islami Jamiat-i-Talaba. IJT denounces coeducation and has physically attacked couples found sitting together on the university's lawn or benches. Some teachers and officials make no secret of their support for such actions.

Modernity is impacting every country's values and eliciting different responses. Türkiye, Morocco and Bangladesh have liberal campuses, much more so than ours. Saudi Arabia and the UAE are now outpacing even them. Whether or not de-segregation has full popular support, this is what their autocratic rulers have decided. On the other hand, even under Iran's strict clerical rule, the cruel death in custody of 22-year-old anti-hijab activist Mahsa Amini led to countrywide protests, suggesting that change is inevitable.

Modernity is also changing Pakistan but far slower than elsewhere. Our conservatives still don't want wives and daughters to work, but their opposition has diminished now that females in one out of five families have outside jobs. Despite all efforts to minimise contact between genders, full segregation is proving impossible.

The Pakistani diaspora in Britain, now into its third generation, remains backward and stuck in a quandary. Many parents, fearing corruption, resist sending their children to British coed schools. This makes for awkwardness in a society that treasures equality of men and women. Even more seriously, this puts many Pak-Brits at the bottom of the social heap for lack of skills and knowledge. Attitudes towards females, derived from enforcing school segregation, can show up late in life.

Islamophobic forces in Britain have long derived strength from grooming gang sex scandals that, much more than other immigrants, implicate British-Pakistani men. While the far right's claims are exaggerated to suit its political agenda, Pakistanis familiar with male attitudes towards females in general, and white girls in particular, say: where there's smoke there's fire.

Gender-related crimes on campus — or elsewhere for that matter — have no easy solution. Would restricting women to female-only workplaces restore purity and virtuousness? Would banning all contact between males and females eliminate sexual misconduct on our coed campuses? Very likely, this would — just as banning all cars and motorbikes would eliminate traffic accidents. However, travelling on horses and camels is not a price that many, including conservatives, are willing to pay. ■

The writer is an Islamabad-based physicist and writer.



Deadly arrogance

RELIGIONS, particularly Islam, are supposed to address the ethical ills that afflict mankind. In fact, in Islamic tradition, *akhlaq* (morals, ethics) is a well-developed science, deriving lessons from the Quran and *ahadith* on how to deal with ethical situations across the spectrum of life. Moreover, the Holy Prophet (PBUH), whose noble birth we celebrate today, is considered the perfect ethical exemplar, who taught us how to behave in family settings and in the workplace, during war and during peace, individually and socially, etc.

Amongst the biggest ethical evils, as per the Quran and the teachings of the Blessed Prophet, are arrogance and pride, which, unfortunately, are found in abundance in all settings. This can range from states practising arrogance, for example, when the powerful and unaccountable unleash death and destruction upon innocents, as Israel and the US are currently doing in Gaza. It can also include how we treat those with less power and money than us, for example domestic staff, street vendors etc.

The Quran is very clear on how arrogance is a reviled trait in the eyes of the Almighty. One of the archetypes of arrogance repeatedly mentioned in the Holy Book is pharaoh, whose haughty utterances and actions are thoroughly condemned. For example, in Surah Naziyat pharaoh, a mere mortal, boasts that "I am your lord, most high." Elsewhere, in Surah Zukhruf, pharaoh wrongly claims that Egypt's mighty Nile flows under his feet. Compare this to the clear warning in Surah Isra, where man is commanded not to walk on the earth arrogantly.

Authentic *ahadith* are equally critical of the arrogant. As per one hadith, it is stated that "there is a special section for the arrogant people in hell". At another point it is stated that "the one who is arrogant will be degraded by Allah", while yet another tradition warns that "the worst kind of pride is considering the creatures lowly".

Throughout his blessed life, the Holy Prophet displayed disdain for arrogance, and preferred humility and simplicity to vanity and ostentation. In fact, apart from his insistence on *tauheed* (monotheism), the tribal aristocrats of Makkah took exception to the fact that he treated the weakest individuals in that society — slaves, women, children, orphans, those without strong tribal affiliation — with dignity and respect. How could a 'low-born' slave be considered equal in the eyes of the Almighty to a 'high-born' merchant of Makkah belonging to a powerful tribe, they wondered. For them, this amounted to 'blasphemy'. Sadly, these pre-Islamic prejudices, with roots in *jahiliya*, have sur-

vived, as even in our society caste, tribe and financial position can define an individual's status in society, rather than the strength of their character.

In fact, these prejudices are not limited to tribal or rural parts of the country; such attitudes thrive even in the cities where wealth — gained by means fair or foul — is the marker of success and status. The poor are an afterthought, not worthy of human dignity. Islam strongly condemns such vile attitudes. In the view of the Most High, the best among humanity are the "most righteous", while in a hadith, those with the best character are equated with those with the best faith. In the divine hierarchy, money, family connections and other ephemeral affiliations have no value; only a person's character counts. And nothing destroys character like arrogance.

The most knowledgeable individual to ever walk the earth — the Holy Prophet, described as the 'City of knowledge' in a hadith — was a picture of humility. Throughout history, even apart from proph-

The Holy Prophet (PBUH) treated the weakest with dignity.

ets, the people of knowledge have always been humble. When they reflect on the realities of the universe — the vastness of the cosmos, the ancientness of time, the deeper mysteries of creation — they realise they know nothing, and prostrate before Allah Almighty, who "taught man which he

knew not". When the people of knowledge express their total helplessness and humility before the Most High, on what basis do the arrogant walk haughtily on the land?

And when arrogance mixes with ignorance, the results are lethal. After all, as per a saying of Hazrat Ali, "ignorance is death for the living". Unfortunately, in our society the arrogant and the ignorant — the 'living dead' in the light of this saying — appear to dominate, while the people of knowledge are brushed aside as weak and unworthy, or harassed for speaking the truth.

But we must remember that arrogance is a death sentence in this world and the next, as the fate of pharaoh and those of his ilk demonstrates. The only solution, as per the Quran and the Holy Prophet's example, lies in humility and character-building, while giving dignity and respect to all, regardless of 'social' and monetary status. ■

The writer is a member of staff.



Blood moon

THIS Sunday, almost six billion people in many parts of the world will witness a total lunar eclipse and blood moon. The strange and eerie darkness of an eclipse has a mystical quality about it that has fascinated human beings since the dawn of time. If the sky is not covered by thick monsoon clouds, people in Pakistan will be able to witness the eclipse as well.

Why a blood moon? As per *National Geographic*, "During totality, sunlight streaming through Earth's atmosphere is bent and scattered, filtering out the blue light and letting the redder wavelengths shine onto the moon. ... Depending on our planet's atmospheric conditions, the shade can range from bright orange to a deep, rusty red." The science of eclipses is fascinating but the myths accompanying them and the history surrounding them are even more so.

Eclipses are mentioned in the scriptures, including in Muslim traditions. Many have interpreted eclipses as a negative sign. For instance, one interpretation of the Talmud is that it is a bad omen for the world, including Israel. Describing the end times, the Christian Bible mentions them as well: "The sun shall be turned into darkness, and the moon into blood, before the great and terrible day of the Lord." Evangelical Christian and some Jewish religious scholars have linked their reading of eclipses to prophetic symbolism, citing groups of four eclipses taking place during a short period (tetrad). Some may well see Sunday's eclipse as the second in such a tetrad.

As if this mix of fact and fiction were not enough for those fascinated by the convergence of science and belief, there are chronicles of historical events that supposedly occurred during a 'blood moon' eclipse. One spectacular event was the Ottoman conquest of Constantinople. The year was 1453 and the Ottomans had their sights set on Constantinople. They had wanted the city for decades and had carried out several unsuccessful sieges of it.

The Christian city was the last bulwark of the declining Roman Empire in the East. The Ottomans had encircled the city. The citizens of Constantinople were weary of war and they were scared of what would befall them. Apparently, the people believed in an ancient prophecy that the city would fall under the shadow of a blood moon and when such a moon actually appeared they must have been terrified. The Ottomans, on the other hand, must have seen it as a sign of victory.

According to some historians, this dual imagery created a potent psychological weapon that had not been present in earlier sieges of the city. In short, the Christians living in the city were convinced that the end of their city was near, despite its strong fortifications. Conversely, the Ottoman warriors felt that this blood moon would lead them to victory and the conquest of Constantinople. The night sky, with a glowing red moon, resembling the one that will be seen on Sunday evening, could well have contributed to the fall of a city that many had believed could not be conquered.

This was not the only time an eclipse became a psychological weapon. Christopher Columbus, the Spanish explorer who sailed out to 'discover' America, managed to calculate the date of an upcoming total lunar eclipse — Feb 29, 1504. Since eclipses are always eerie spectacles, he capitalised on the fact and

Sunday's
eclipse
will make
for a
haunting
spectacle.

told the Native American Arawaks that the divine powers were angry at them for denying him and his crew food and supplies. When the eclipse actually took place a few days later, the people were frightened into giving him and his crew

food and water and Columbus and his men were saved.

For time immemorial, eclipses have also been given an astrological hue, with the water sign Pisces, that is supposed to affect marine events, believed to have a 'deep connection' with the cosmic event. New beginnings and a cosmic reset are predicted by astrologers for those born under the water sign.

But regardless of your zodiac sign, you will be able to witness an extraordinary and spectacular event on Sunday evening — if the night skies are uncovered. When you experience the sight of a glowing red moon against the deep darkness of the universe above, you might reflect on the same haunting spectacle as ancient soothsayers, Ottoman soldiers and the Arawak people, who were duped by Christopher Columbus via an expected celestial event, did. The history of the world is not just told through history books but also through the night sky. ■

The writer is an attorney teaching constitutional law and political philosophy.
rafia.zakaria@gmail.com

Constant preparedness

Page 6

RAWALPINDI: The Prime Minister, Mr Zulfikar Ali Bhutto, has said "the defence of Pakistan now is in the hands of a force which can no longer be made prey to a confusion about its aims and functions". In a message on the Defence of Pakistan Day, the Prime Minister has paid homage to the Shaheeds, who made the supreme sacrifice so that Pakistan may live in freedom and honour. He said: "We must rededicate ourselves to the ideology of Pakistan and make a solemn vow that none of us, soldier or civilian, will fail in constant preparedness to defend the nation's integrity."

[Meanwhile, as reported by news agencies from Cairo,] Sudanese President Jaafar el Numeiry said today [Sept 5] that an attempted coup against his Government had been crushed. "Everything is over," the President said in a broadcast to the nation several hours after the early-morning rebellion led by an obscure paratroop colonel had been defeated in what was officially described as a short, fierce battle. President Numeiry told Egyptian President Anwar Sadat over the telephone that the situation in Sudan was calm... Earlier, officials of the Numeiry Government had announced that the army was in full control.

Reds break through

Page 6

TOKYO: Strong American counterattacks slowed the breakthrough drive by 30,000 Communists on Tuesday [Sept 5] down the Korean east coast towards the key transport hub of Kyongju, which is 17 miles south-west of Pohang, 35 miles east of Taegu and 47 miles north of Pusan. The Communist assault on the eastern flank of Allied defences had penetrated the South Korean lines west of Pohang on a wide front and they poured across the Pohan-Yongchon road... .

Then Lt. General Walton Walker, Commander of ground forces in Korea, threw ... American forces against the Reds in another of his exhibitions of mobility which had thwarted the enemy time after time. He sought to wreck the Communist bid to isolate Pohang, to flank Taegu and to roll the line back on Pusan. By nightfall the counter-attacking American and South Korean forces were dug in along ridges and across a river valley, seven miles north of Kyongju.

Behind the hastily reformed Allied front bands of a dozen to 400 North Koreans on Tuesday night were attacking small South Korean units, throwing roadblocks across the highways and disrupting communications.— News agencies

A wide gap between Islam and Muslims

Page 6



HUMAN history knows no figure whose moral imagination reshaped society spiritually, socially and politically as profoundly as did Prophet Muhammad (peace be upon him). His message of justice, equality and dignity for all was not bound by geography or barred by time. In today's world, scarred by wars, conflicts, injustices, displacement, hunger and inequality, the Prophet's teachings remain the most enduring and practical path to peace and harmony.

Unlike the elites of Makkah, the Prophet stood shoulder to shoulder with the poor, the slaves, the vulnerable, and the voiceless. His earliest followers came not from the privileged classes, but from among the ones exploited and trampled by society. He rejected an order where lineage or wealth defined worth, and instead lifted the downtrodden with the assurance that the most honoured among them was the most righteous.

His solidarity with the underprivileged was no accident. It was the very essence of his mission. Yet, in much of the Muslim world today, rulers and elites have betrayed this legacy. Oligarchies thrive, privileges multiply, and the poor are pushed further to the margins. This widening gulf between the rulers and the ruled has hollowed out the spirit of social equality.

When the Prophet left the world, he left behind an immortal legacy of mercy and justice. Today, however, we see in parts of the Muslim world, particularly in the oil-rich Gulf region, an addiction to extravagance: castles in deserts, fleets of luxury liners, planes, and billions spent on pomp. This politics of indulgence is the sharpest betrayal of the Prophet's path.

A world torn apart by conflicts, hunger wars and human misery needs a leadership that builds schools, hospitals and research centres, not golden towers and lavish spectacles. The Prophet's farewell sermon

at Arafat remains humanity's most timeless manifesto. It enshrined equality of mankind, sanctity of life, justice and state protection for the marginalised. From the Universal Declaration of Human Rights of the United Nations to the anti-apartheid struggle of Nelson Mandela, the modern world is based on all these very elements.

In practice, however, the international system, especially, after World War II, is skewed to serve the powerful. The UN, once envisioned as humanity's conscience, is paralysed by the undemocratic veto of the P5 group. Wars rage, while resolutions die in silence. The weak are trampled because the law bows before the mighty.

Today, there are more than two billion Muslims around the world, but many Muslim societies wallow in ignominy, humiliation and decline. This is so because we have abandoned the progressive message of Islam — education, innovation, justice and human dignity. We focus more on rituals than actions, and on slogans than sacrifices. We consume imported knowledge instead of producing or promoting indigenous research. We glorify division over unity, and rhetoric over reforms.

If Muslims recover and rediscover these abandoned priorities, they will regain their dignity in the comity of nations; not through borrowed prestige, but through genuine contribution.

The Prophet began as one man with a few faithful by his side. He did not inherit privilege, but his moral authority truly conquered hearts and built civilisations.

Qamer Soomro
Shikarpur

Grave danger

Page 6

WE talk a lot about national security, borders, geopolitics and external threats. However, the gravest danger lies not outside, but within our own borders. True security is about protecting people, and ensuring that they are well-fed and healthy. According to Global Report on Food Crisis 2025, a staggering 2.1 million children aged under five years were identified within a short five-month period as acutely malnourished, particularly in Sindh, Balochistan and Khyber Pakhtunkhwa (KP). These are not just numbers. They represent immense suffering of families struggling for survival.

While the national leadership navigates complex international power games, a silent humanitarian emergency is getting worse at home. How can we prioritise diplomatic manoeuvres when millions are facing immediate hunger? What good is a strong state if its youngest citizens are starving?

It is time to expand our definition of national security. Beyond borders and defence, food security, child health and the dignity of feeding one's family are fundamental to a secure nation.

Ignoring this internal crisis actually means putting at risk something far more valuable than political grandstanding.

Zahid Maqsood Sheikh

Lahore



Hazardous activity

AN upsetting video has been doing the rounds on social media, showing a crocodile attacking a woman washing clothes in Nara Canal near Sukkur. Unfortunately, this is not the first time a tragedy like this has taken place. In July 2021, a four-year-old girl was eaten alive by a 16-foot crocodile as she helped her mother wash clothes. These attacks are the result of a growing crocodile population in the canal system, and lack of safe water resources for the nearby communities.

Hundreds of crocodiles in the area have been reported, but the people continue to use the canal for washing and other daily activities, putting lives at constant risk. The authorities must determine and make safe water-collecting points that should be crocodile-free.

Also, there should be routine wildlife patrols to survey and remove dangerous crocodiles when necessary. Public awareness campaigns to educate the local communities regarding safe practices around the canal should also be initiated. Finally, people should be provided water for drinking and washing to reduce their use of unsafe waterways.

Relevant authorities need to take urgent action to prevent further loss of innocent lives. People of Sukkur have the right to live safely and with dignity instead of living in constant fear of crocodile attacks.

case earlier. When asked, its representatives told me that I could now use 15GB of data compared to four in the past, along with 3,500 minutes talking time and 3,000 messages. But I do not want all that. I just want 4GB data and a talking time worth no more than 100 minutes.

Why is there no cheaper package for consumers like me? The official reply is that I can always use a pre-paid package or switch to another cellular company. This is what corporate fraud looks like.

Shakir Lakhani
Karachi

Exploitative company

THIS is with reference to the editorial 'Damning audit report' (Aug 23), which, among other things, pointed out that a telecommunication company over-charged its customers to the tune of Rs6.58 billion in a single financial year.

Over the last couple of years, the same company has been regularly increasing the price of its basic post-paid package, with the result that I am now paying more than twice the amount than what was the

Agricultural credit should be expanded to small landholders trying to rebuild their lives, not limited to machinery imports that bypass the most vulnerable.

Investment must prioritise climate-resilient infrastructure rooted in public need, not profit corridors designed for privatisation.

Only through such people-centred reforms can we begin to re-embed our economy in lasting justice and collective care. Markets cannot mourn. They cannot rebuild homes or bury children. Only people-centred policies can. Let this be the nation's great transformation.

Mahnoor Aftab
Karachi

Trade and floods

IN the latest monthly economic outlook report for August, the Finance Ministry celebrated a new trade agreement with the United States, projecting export growth and macroeconomic stability. Yet, buried in the same report is a quiet warning: flood-related damages may disrupt food supplies, and strain public finances. This is a dangerous contradiction.

Pakistan's economy today is shaped by external deals and fiscal targets, while well over 800 lives have so far been lost in this year's monsoon-inspired floods. The number of people displaced in Punjab and Khyber Pakhtunkhwa is believed to have crossed the 1.5 million mark. What good is a trade stability when families sleep along roadsides? What does business confidence mean to the farmers whose fields are underwater?

As Karl Polanyi reminded us in *The Great Transformation*, "markets are not natural forces; they are constructed by society and can be reconstructed to serve it". If our economy is to reflect the realities of those it claims to serve, we must redirect export gains towards flood recovery rather than concentrating the benefits in stimulus packages for the elite.

Govt faces setback as foreign funds exit bonds

Page 7

Outflows of \$73m from T-bills outstripped inflows of \$44m in two months

By Shahid Iqbal

KARACHI: Foreign investment in domestic bonds has recorded net outflows during the first two months of the current fiscal year, despite moderate inflows in the same period.

The State Bank's latest data showed that outflows from treasury bills amounted to \$73 million against inflows of \$44m — 64pc higher than the receipts.

Analysts said the trend, if it persists, could disappoint policy-makers who closely monitor foreign currency movements, particularly the US dollar.

They noted that a sharp cut in interest rates had eroded foreign appetite for government papers. The policy rate has been slashed by half to 11pc, reducing returns on T-bills.

"This is not the only factor," said one analyst. "The weakening of the US dollar against major currencies like the euro has created global uncertainty for investors, which may last longer than expected."

Investment in T-bills remains concentrated in a few countries, led by the UK. Inflows from the UK were just \$13m, while out-

flows stood at \$52.5m — nearly four times higher. By contrast, the UAE recorded inflows of \$10m against outflows of \$5m, while inflows from the US totalled \$0.85m against outflows of \$5m. Bahrain posted outflows of \$10.5m without any inflows.

Despite repeated efforts, the government has struggled to attract sustained foreign portfolio investment. Instead, it has relied heavily on workers' remittances, which reached a record \$38.3bn in FY25. However, the outlook has been clouded by the government's decision to cut costly incentives for remittance inflows.

The incentives cost Rs124bn in FY25, up 70pc from Rs73bn in FY24, prompting criticism from

economists and a former State Bank governor that banks were being unduly enriched. In response, the government moved to reduce costs, despite warnings from banks and money changers that the step could reverse the strong growth trend.

Some banks reported losses on the remittance business, saying they were paying higher-than-market rates to attract inflows. The cut in incentives, they warned, could weaken momentum.

Still, remittances in August stood at \$3.2bn, broadly in line with last year's trend. The robust inflows enabled the State Bank to purchase \$7.8bn from the inter-bank market during FY25, strengthening reserves and helping keep the exchange rate stable.

Govt raises Rs654bn via PIBs

KARACHI: The government on Friday raised the highest amount for the longest tenor of 15 years by selling Pakistan Investment Bonds (PIBs), the State Bank reported.

Like treasury bills, the auction fetched more than the target. Against the set target of Rs400bn, the government mobilised Rs654.3bn.

Notably, investors offered the largest amount for 15-year PIBs, submitting bids worth Rs497.5bn. Of this, the government raised Rs280bn — the highest amount secured for a single tenor. Bankers said the response indicated investor confidence that interest rates may ease in the coming months, with little expectation of further increases.

The second-highest amount was raised through 10-year bonds at Rs205bn. Analysts observed that the shift towards longer tenors would help the government improve its debt profile by relying more on long-term borrowings instead of short-term liabilities.

The auction attracted total bids of Rs1.28tr. The government accepted Rs638.88bn through competitive bids and another Rs15.4bn through non-competitive bids. Other maturities raised smaller amounts: Rs108.5bn for five years, Rs5.6bn for three years and Rs39.5bn for two years.

In the wake of widespread flooding, some bankers said the government may need to borrow more from domestic banks, even if foreign assistance materialises, to meet urgent funding needs for relief and reconstruction.—Staff Reporter

KE's sukuk

Page 7

KARACHI: K-Electric has raised Rs2 billion through its first retail sukuk initial public offering after drawing overwhelming investor response. However, the IPO was over-subscribed to the tune of Rs4.4bn.



TOMATOES soar to Rs300 per kg, while onion and wheat flour prices surge during the week. —PPI/file

Perishables push inflation up 5pc

SPI rises for seventh straight week

By Mubarak Zeb Khan

ISLAMABAD: Short-term inflation, measured by the Sensitive Price Index (SPI), rose 5.07pc year-on-year in the week ending Sept 4, driven by soaring retail prices of perishable food items.

SPI inflation has been on an upward trajectory for the past seven weeks, fuelled mainly by sharp increases in the prices of tomatoes, onions, potatoes, rice, chicken, liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) and wheat flour. On a weekly basis, inflation increased by 1.29pc, according to official data released on Friday.

Tomatoes led the surge, retailing at up to Rs300 per kg in Islamabad,

while sugar climbed to Rs195–200 per kg. Meat prices also maintained a steady upward trend in recent weeks.

Although overall short-term inflation appears slower due to last year's high base, the sharp escalation in perishables and a few key essentials has reversed the stable trend seen earlier this year.

The SPI had previously declined in March after 11 straight weeks of inflation above 40pc, which began from 29pc on Nov 8, 2023. Weekly inflation hit a record 48.35pc in early May 2023 before easing to 24.4pc in late August, only to surge again past 40pc by mid-November 2023.

Weekly changes: Items showing the highest week-on-week increase included tomatoes (46.03pc), wheat flour (25.41pc), onions (8.57pc), basmati broken rice (2.62pc), garlic (2.04pc), potatoes (1.38pc), moong pulse (1.29pc), bread (1.19pc), LPG (0.88pc) and

shirting (0.27pc).

Commodities that declined included bananas (3.86pc), diesel (0.91pc), sugar (0.13pc) and mustard oil (0.10pc).

Annual changes: Year-on-year, tomatoes surged 83.45pc, ladies' sandals 55.62pc, wheat flour 30.27pc, gas charges for Q1 29.85pc, sugar 27.43pc, gur 13.21pc, beef 13.15pc, moong pulse 12.99pc, firewood 11.47pc, vegetable ghee (2.5kg) 11.36pc and chicken 10.89pc.

Onions, however, dropped 47pc, followed by garlic (25.50pc), mash pulse (22.93pc), potatoes (19.25pc), gram pulse (19.04pc), electricity charges for Q1 (18.12pc), Lipton tea (17.93pc), masoor pulse (6.07pc), IRRI-6/9 rice (4.60pc) and LPG (3.71pc). The SPI, based on 51 essential items collected from 50 markets in 17 cities, showed that prices of 23 items rose, four fell and 24 remained unchanged during the week under review.

IT ministry, Alibaba partner to boost digital trade

Page 7

By Kalbe Ali

ISLAMABAD: The Ministry of Information Technology has partnered with Alibaba to boost digital trade and support SME growth in Pakistan.

Minister for IT and Telecommunication Shaza Fatima Khawaja and Roger Luo, head of South and Southeast Asia at Alibaba.com, signed a memorandum of understanding in this regard in Beijing during the 2nd Pakistan-China B2B Investment Conference. Alibaba.com, a leading global B2B e-commerce platform, has signed the MoU with Ignite — National Technology Fund, which operates under the IT ministry.

The collaboration aims to strengthen Pakistan's digital economy and expand global opportunities for small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs) and startups.

Under the agreement, Alibaba.com will organise and facilitate online and offline promotional activities, such as Pakistan trade shows and an online national pavilion. It will also deliver targeted B2B e-commerce training and provide AI-powered tools to selected SMEs and startups.

Ignite will assist in implementation by identifying potential exporters, coordinating seminars in major cities, and promoting Alibaba-led initiatives across the country.

Shaza Fatima said Pakistan

stood at the cusp of global e-commerce opportunities, where the passion and entrepreneurial skills of its youth could enable them to showcase their products and abilities at the international level. She described the partnership with Alibaba.com as an important step for Pakistan's digital economy.

"By equipping our SMEs and startups with advanced e-commerce tools and access to global markets, and by aligning our institutions with international best practices, we aim to foster innovation, support export growth, and strengthen Pakistan's participation in global digital trade," she added.

Alibaba.com has already played an active role in Pakistan, rolling out its Trade Assurance service

with an 85 per cent activation rate within months of its launch. It has also helped sellers adopt its AI-powered Smart Assistant, which is now used by 80pc of Pakistani sellers, enhancing trust and operational efficiency.

In the second quarter of 2025, Pakistan recorded a 60pc year-on-year increase in new suppliers on Alibaba.com, led by the apparel, sports and entertainment, and surgical instruments sectors.

Following the signing of MoU, the Pakistani delegation visited Alibaba's campus in Beijing and discussed ways to expand Pakistan's role in global supply chains, improve e-commerce training for SMEs, and explore further cooperation in AI and digital trade facilitation.

Weak reforms fuel Pakistan's energy black hole

Page 7

IIF says circular debt exceeds Rs4.6tr, equal to 4pc of GDP, fuelling fiscal risks and stalling reforms

By Khaleeq Kiani

ISLAMABAD: With limited progress on reforms and over Rs4.6 trillion in accumulated liabilities, Pakistan's energy sector continues to strain the economy, weighed down by weak collections, theft, poor infrastructure, governance failures and market inefficiencies.

According to a detailed report by the Washington-based Institute of International Finance (IIF), "taken together, there is about 4pc of GDP worth of debt stemming from the energy sector. The repercussions reverberate throughout the economy, not only impacting the fiscal but also growth, inflation, the external balance and the financial sector."

Circular debt has plagued the country since 2006. While successive governments have made periodic payments to ease the pressure — including a recent Rs800bn settlement — the flow of new debt remains unchecked. As of June 2025, the stock of circular debt stood at Rs1.6tr (1.4pc of GDP), compounded by another Rs3tr (2.6pc of GDP) owed by power producers to the oil and gas sector.

The report said the debt has severe fiscal consequences. To contain high servicing costs, the government created Power Holding Limited (PHL), a special purpose vehicle mandated to inject liquidity into the energy market, hold power sector debt, and reduce financing costs. But by absorbing PHL liabilities into the national books, the government effectively increased public debt and assumed additional risks.

Currently, circular debt accounts for about 2.2pc of total government debt, excluding arrears of state-run generation companies to fuel suppliers. Along with energy subsidies, this has exerted persistent pressure on public finances, forcing the diversion of resources away from social programmes, development spending and infrastructure.

Spillover effects

The IIF stressed that the challenge extends far beyond fiscal management. On the financial side, borrowing through PHL has relied heavily on domestic banks, contributing to the crowding out of private sector credit.

On the growth front, recurring power outages — often imposed in areas with poor recovery rates — disrupt industrial

activity, investment and productivity, undermining competitiveness. At the same time, high electricity tariffs feed into headline inflation, while a heavy reliance on imported fuel aggravates external imbalances, particularly during episodes of sharp rupee depreciation.

Policy responses

Recognising the gravity of the problem, the authorities have introduced a series of measures. These include approval of the Competitive Trading Bilateral Contract Market (CTBCM), designed to break the monopoly of distribution companies (Discos) by allowing large consumers to negotiate directly with power producers.

Contracts with independent power producers are being shifted from the "take-or-pay" model — under which payments are made regardless of consumption — to "take-and-pay" arrangements where only consumed energy is paid for. At the same time, electricity tariffs have been raised, subsidies are being better targeted, and steps have been taken to address theft, improve bill recoveries and reduce technical and distribution losses.

A gradual shift towards domestic energy sources such as hydropower and coal is also under way in an effort to cut reliance on expensive imported fuels.

Still unsustainable

Despite these initiatives, the IIF observed that reforms have not delivered meaningful improvements in sectoral performance. The recent fall in circular debt during FY24/25 was largely due to a one-off clearance made possible by commercial loans rather than structural fixes.

"As inefficiencies in distribution companies, T&D losses and poor collection rates persist, large bailouts are not a coherent or sustainable strategy in the long run," the report warned. It underlined that systematic inefficiencies remain deeply embedded in the energy sector, ensuring that the flow of debt continues.

Reform deficit

The institute pointed out that many of the structural issues behind circular debt are well known but difficult to resolve due to entrenched institutional reluctance and vested interests. The problem, it said, has become the "clearest example of why Pakistan's reforms continue to fall short and why fiscal risks remain entrenched."

"Until this hurdle is overcome, circular debt will continue to weigh heavily on the economy, eroding fiscal space, constraining growth and fuelling instability," it concluded.

Sales of BYD cars cross 2,000 in six months

Page 7

By Our Staff Reporter

KARACHI: Hub Power Company (Hubco) has disclosed that BYD has sold over 2,000 cars in less than six months, while more than 500 orders have already been placed for its Shark model. The company is currently importing completely built units (CBUs) under the normal duty regime.

Hubco is setting up a completely knocked down (CKD) assembly plant in Gharo with an annual production capacity of 25,000 units. According to a report by Asad Ali of Topline Securities, based on the company's analyst briefing, financial close is expected in the last quarter of 2025. The project carries an estimated cost of \$150 million, structured on a 60:40 debt-to-equity ratio.

Both foreign and local lenders are on board, with a term sheet already signed. Hubco expects CKD production to begin within 24 months.

Regarding ownership, the company clarified that the project is a 50:50 joint venture between Hub Power Holding — a wholly owned Hubco subsidiary — and Mega Conglomerate.

BYD has not taken an equity stake in the venture. Globally, BYD has pursued 100pc ownership in markets such as Thailand and Brazil, making this its first global partnership without equity participation.

On EV charging, the company noted that while chargers were initially sourced from Europe, Chinese suppliers have now made them more affordable. It added that EV charging stations become financially viable with usage of three cars per day.

Hubco plans to install chargers every 150-200 kilometres along the Karachi-Peshawar motorway over the next six months.

Separately, Sazgar Engineering Works Ltd plans to roll out CKD models of the TANK-500 and CANNON plug-in hybrid vehicles (PHEVs) by March 31, 2026. The company had earlier launched its first CKD PHEV — the Haval H6 1.5L — on Aug 16, 2025, according to its FY25 annual report.

Stocks hit all-time high above 154,000 points

Page 7

By Muhammad Kashif

KARACHI: Bulls extended their run on Friday as the benchmark KSE-100 index closed at yet another all-time high, marking the sixth consecutive session of gains on the back of strong institutional interest in banking and cement stocks.

The index surged 1,612 points, or 1.06pc, to settle at 154,277.19, comfortably above the 154,000 barrier. During the session, it touched an intraday peak of 154,511 points, before closing near the day's high. On a weekly basis, the KSE-100 added 5,659 points, or 3.81pc, after opening at 149,079 points.

However, the surge in equities comes at a time when the wider economy faces growing risks from devastating floods in Punjab, now heading towards Sindh. The calamity threatens standing crops, disrupts supply chains, and

PAKISTAN STOCK EXCHANGE

T H E T O P F I V E R S

GAINERS

Sitara Chemical	79.77
Siemens Pakistan	50.17
Ismail Industries	45.54
Rafhan Maize	41.50
ZIL Ltd	33.36

(Share values in rupees)

LOSERS

PIA Holding CoB	834.67
Hoechst Pakistan	96.79
Unilever Foods	59.31
Nestle Pakistan	40.16
Al-Abbas Sugar	24.91

LEADERS*

The Bank of Punjab	146.09
First Nat'l. Equities	55.75
Fauji Foods	50.93
Bank Makramah	46.92
Power Cement	43.23

* Volume in millions of traded shares

I N D I C A T O R S

	Friday	Previous	Change
KSE 100-SHARE INDEX (Points)	154,277.19	152,665.72	▲ 1,611.47
KSE 30-SHARE INDEX (Points)	47,063.22	46,499.67	▲ 563.55
MARKET CAPITAL (Rs billion)	18,133.121	17,982.608	▲ 150.512
TRADING VALUE (Rs billion)	59.949	46.053	▲ 13.896

could fuel inflationary pressures, posing fresh challenges to the country's fragile recovery.

Ali Najib, Deputy Head of Trading at Arif Habib Ltd, said the index "shattered

154,000" as the market closed the week "in style". He added that momentum suggested further upside in the coming sessions.

National Bank of Pakistan (NBP) stole the

spotlight, hitting the upper circuit within minutes of its corporate briefing, which raised hopes of a sizeable year-end dividend. Although the NBP Act restricts payouts to

annual results, investors welcomed management's indication of not remaining overcapitalised. The stock jumped 9.88pc to close at Rs171.98.

Cement stocks followed

ACTIVITY

Total listed	532
Active	479
Gainers	239
Losers	210

PARTICIPANTS

Foreign	▼ \$5.61m
Companies	▲ \$3.50m
Banks	▼ \$4.59m
Mutual Funds	▲ \$0.91m
Individuals	▲ \$6.89m

suit. DG Khan Cement rose 10pc, while Power Cement, Gharibwal Cement, Maple Leaf Cement and Lucky Cement gained between 3-7.5pc, reflecting broad-based strength in the sector.

Market participation was robust, with trading volume rising 13pc to 1.07 billion shares, while trading value surged 30.17% to almost Rs60 billion. Bank of Punjab dominated the volume chart once again with 146m shares, underscoring risk appetite in a market already at record levels.

Analysts said the 150,000 mark had re-emerged as a strong support zone, underpinned by optimism over narrowing trade deficits and expectations of a farmer relief package. With momentum intact, investors appeared confident of further highs in the days ahead. According to Topline Securities, the index's extension was largely driven by institutional buying in banks and cement shares.

Trump says India and Russia appear 'lost to deepest, darkest China'

Page 8

WASHINGTON: President Donald Trump said on Friday India and Russia seem to have been “lost” to China after their leaders met Chinese President Xi Jinping this week, expressing annoyance at New Delhi and Moscow as Beijing pushes a new world order.

“Looks like we’ve lost India and Russia to deepest, darkest, China. May they have a long and prosperous future together!” Trump wrote in a social media post accompanying a photo of the three leaders together at Xi’s summit in China.

Asked about Trump’s post, India’s foreign ministry told reporters in New Delhi that it had no comment.

The Chinese foreign ministry did not immediately reply to a request for comment, and representatives for the Kremlin could not be immediately reached.

Xi Jinping hosted more than 20 leaders of non-Western countries for the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) earlier this week in the Chinese port city of Tianjin, including Russian President Vladimir Putin and Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

Putin and Modi were seen holding hands at the summit as they walked toward Xi before all three men stood side by side.

The US president has chilled ties with India amid trade tensions and other disputes. Trump this week said he was “very disappointed” in Putin, but not worried about growing Russia-China ties.

He has been frustrated at his inability to convince Russia and Ukraine to reach an end to their war. He told reporters on Thursday night at the White House that he planned to talk to Putin soon.—Reuters

US sends F-35s to Puerto Rico amid Venezuela tensions

Page 8

WASHINGTON: The United States sent 10 F-35 fighter jets to Puerto Rico as part of its war on drug cartels amid mounting tensions with Venezuela over Washington's military build-up in the Caribbean.

The planes will join US warships already deployed to the southern Caribbean as President Donald Trump steps up pressure on Venezuelan President Nicolas Maduro, whom the United States accuses of leading a drug cartel.

The standoff has grown in recent days as the Pentagon said two Venezuelan military planes flew near a US Navy vessel in international waters on Thursday in a "highly provocative" move.

US forces on Tuesday blew up an alleged drug boat in the Caribbean that

Trump said belonged to the Tren de Aragua, a Venezuelan criminal organisation he tied to Maduro, killing 11 people.

The high-tech F-35 jets will be deployed to an airfield in Puerto Rico, a US Caribbean island territory of more than three million people.

Maduro — a leftist firebrand whose election victory last year was seen by Washington as illegitimate — has denounced the US build-up as "the greatest threat our continent has seen in the last 100 years".

Declaring his country prepared for "armed struggle in defence of the national territory", he has mobilised Venezuela's military, which numbers 340,000, and 'eight million reservists'.—AFP

EU hits Google with \$3.45bn anti-trust fine

Page 8

BRUSSELS: Google was hit with a 2.95-billion-euro (\$3.45bn) anti-trust fine by the European Union on Friday for anti-competitive practices in its lucrative adtech business, a sharp sanction against the firm that could rile up US President Donald Trump.

The fine, the fourth penalty Google has faced in its decade-long fight with EU competition regulators, comes amid bubbling trade tensions between major global powers and US threats of retaliation over EU scrutiny of American tech firms.

The move by the European Commission was triggered by a complaint from the European Publishers Council. Trump, who has hit Europe with trade tariffs, has threatened to retaliate against the European Union for any push back against Big Tech.

While Google plans to appeal, the commission has warned of stronger remedies — including potential divestitures — if the company fails to address its conflicts of interest. The case underscores growing transatlantic friction over digital market regulation and the EU's push to rein in dominant platforms.

The EU competition enforcer had originally planned to hand out the fine on Monday, but opposition from EU trade chief Maros Sefcovic on concerns about the impact on US tariffs on European

cars derailed anti-trust chief Teresa Ribera's plan.

The commission said Google favoured its own online display technology services that reinforced its own ad exchange AdX's central role in the adtech supply chain and allowed Google to charge high fees for its service, to the detriment of rivals and online publishers.

"Google has abused its market power since 2014 until today," the EU watchdog said.

It ordered Google to stop the self-preferencing practices and take measures to cease its inherent conflicts of interest. The company has 60 days to inform the commission how it plans to comply with this order, and another 30 days to do so.

The commission reiterated its preliminary view that Google should divest part of its services, but said it wants to first hear and assess Google's compliance efforts.

"Google must now come forward with a serious remedy to address its conflicts of interest, and if it fails to do so, we will not hesitate to impose strong remedies," Ribera said in a statement.

"Digital markets exist to serve people and must be grounded in trust and fairness. And when markets fail, public institutions must act to prevent dominant players from abusing their power," she said.

Google criticised the EU decision and said it would challenge it in court.

"The European Commission's decision about our ad tech services is wrong and we will appeal. It imposes an unjustified fine and requires changes that will hurt thousands of European businesses by making it harder for them to make money," Lee-Anne Mulholland, Vice President, Global Head of Regulatory Affairs, said in a statement.

"There's nothing anti-competitive in providing services for ad buyers and sellers, and there are more alternatives to our services than ever before."

The latest fine compared with a record 4.3bn euro penalty handed out to Google in 2018, 2.42bn euros in 2017 and a 1.49bn euros in 2019.

The European Publishers Council lamented the absence of a breakup order.

"A fine will not fix Google's abuse of its adtech," its executive director Angela Mills Wade said. "Without strong and decisive enforcement, Google will simply write this off as a cost of business while consolidating its dominance in the AI era, perpetuating unfair competition and weakening news media and publishing companies which rely on advertising revenues," she said.—Reuters

475 workers held in raid at S. Korean firm's plant in US

Page 8

WASHINGTON: Hundreds of workers at a Hyundai Motor car battery facility under construction in Georgia were detained in a major raid by US authorities late on Thursday, stopping work on a plant that is one of the South Korean automaker's major investments in the United States.

About 475 workers were arrested, making it the largest single-site enforcement operation in the US Department of Homeland Security's (DHS) history.

President Donald Trump's administration has been escalating a crackdown on immigrants, disrupting businesses around the country, even as the White House has encouraged more inflows from foreign investors.

The arrests could exacerbate tensions between Washington and Seoul, a key ally and investor in the US. The countries have been at odds over the details of a trade deal that includes \$350 billion of investments. Just last month, South Korea pledged \$150bn in US investments — including \$26bn from Hyundai Motor — at a summit.

Homeland Security officials said the workers it arrested were barred from working in the US after crossing the border illegally or overstaying visas. The investigation took place over several months, Steven Schrank, special agent in charge of investigations for Georgia, said during a press briefing.

"This was not an immigration operation where agents went into the premises, rounded up folks and put them on buses," he said.

Under Trump, Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) a part of DHS, has driven the Republican leader's sweeping crackdown on migrants, bolstered by record funding and new latitude to conduct raids.

Trump has said he wants to deport "the worst of the worst" criminals, but ICE figures have shown a rise in non-criminals being picked up.—Reuters

Thai tycoon wins vote to become PM

Page 8

BANGKOK: Right-wing Thai tycoon Anutin Charnvirakul was confirmed on Friday by parliament as the nation's next prime minister, ousting the dominant populist Shinawatra dynasty.

The Shinawatras have been a mainstay of Thai politics for the past two decades, sparring with the pro-monarchy, pro-military establishment that views them as a threat to traditional social order.

Their Pheu Thai party has monopolised the top office since 2023 elections, but they have been bedevilled by a series of setbacks and a court ruling that resulted in dynasty heiress Paetongtarn Shinawatra's

sacking as prime minister last week.

Construction magnate Anutin Charnvirakul rushed into the power vacuum, cobbling together a coalition of opposition blocs to shut out Pheu Thai.

Thaksin Shinawatra, the dynasty patriarch, flew out of the kingdom in the hours ahead of Friday's vote and was bound for Dubai, where he said he would visit friends and seek medical treatment.

Anutin won 311 votes, securing a comfortable majority of the 492 MPs in the National Assembly, official final results showed — comfortably outstripping Pheu Thai's candidate—AFP

WHO backs weight-loss drugs to treat diabetes, obesity

Page 8

Urges increased access to affordable generic medicines in developing countries

PARIS: The World Health Organisation recommended a range of blockbuster weight-loss drugs to treat diabetes and obesity globally for the first time on Friday, calling for cheap generic versions to be made available for

people in developing countries.

The new generation of appetite-suppressing drugs called GLP-1 agonists — which include the brands Ozempic, Wegovy and Mounjaro — have exploded in popularity due to their ability to help people significantly lose weight.

More than 3.7 million people died from illnesses related to being overweight or obese in 2021 according to WHO figures — more than top infectious killers malaria, tuberculosis and HIV combined.

However, the sky-high prices of GLP-1 drugs, which can cost over \$1,000 a month in the United States, have raised concerns they will not be made available in poorer nations where they could save the most lives.

On Friday, the WHO added semaglutide — the active ingredient in Danish pharma giant Novo Nordisk's Ozempic and Wegovy — and the tirzepatide used in US company Eli Lilly's Mounjaro to its list of essential medicines for adults worldwide.

To ensure these “life-saving” injectable drugs reach people who need them most, the UN agency said in a statement it encouraged “generic competition to drive down prices”.

Andrew Hill, a pharmacology researcher at Liverpool University, pointed to research showing that generic semaglutide could be mass produced in India for as little as \$4 a month.

“What we’re asking is for Novartis and Eli Lilly to do the responsible thing and make their

treatments available on a world-wide scale at an affordable, generic price,” he told *AFP*.

The patent for semaglutide will run out in some countries, including Canada, India and China, next year, which could also result in a surge in generic production.

GLP-1 drugs, which have some side effects including nausea, were originally developed for diabetes, but research has increasingly suggested they could help with a broad range of health problems including

addiction.

A study published in the *JAMA* medical journal this week found that patients with heart problems taking the drugs had more than a 40 per cent lower risk of being hospitalised or dying prematurely.

One in eight people worldwide are now obese, while in 2022 more than 800 million people were living with diabetes, according to the WHO. The WHO also named a range of cancer drugs to its essential medicines list.—AFP



(FROM left) Producer Jennifer Candy-Sullivan, Ryan Reynolds, Rosemary Candy, Chris Candy and director Colin Hanks attend the premiere of Canadian movie *John Candy: I Like Me* at the Toronto International Film Festival.—AFP

Toronto film fest kicks off with politics

TORONTO: The Toronto International Film Festival (TIFF) kicked off on a political note on Thursday, as Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney and the Obamas delivered opening remarks before Hollywood A-listers arrived to take centre stage.

North America's biggest film festival is celebrating its 50th edition.

Stars including Daniel Craig, Sydney Sweeney and Matthew McConaughey are set to unveil their latest movies over the next 11 days.

But the arrival of actors and filmmakers from the United States comes against the backdrop of US President Donald Trump's threats to take over his northern neighbour.

Taking the stage before TIFF's open-

ing film, a documentary about home-grown comic John Candy, Carney warned that "our sovereignty, our identity has come under threat".

"And when Canadians heard those threats, they channelled their inner John Candy," he said, of the beloved *Planes, Trains and Automobiles* comic to raucous cheers.

Former US president Barack Obama and his wife Michelle introduced *The Eyes of Ghana*, a new documentary from the movie production company they set up after leaving the White House.

The film unearths long-lost footage of Kwame Nkrumah, Ghana's first president, who was overthrown in a coup after creating a personality cult around himself as the "Redeemer".—AFP

Five ministers boycot cabinet to protest disarming of Hezbollah

Page 9

BEIRUT: All five Shia members of the Lebanese cabinet left a session on Friday after the government gave the go-ahead to a plan by the army to disarm Hezbollah.

The five ministers left the room as soon as the army chief made his entry.

Information minister Paul Morcos told reporters after the session that the government welcomed the plan, but stopped short of saying the cabinet had formally passed it.

He said the army would begin implementing the plan according to its "limited" logistical, material and personnel capabilities, which might require "additional time (and) additional effort".

A national divide over Hezbollah's disarmament has taken centre stage in Lebanon since last year's devastating bombings by Israel, which upended a power balance long dominated by the Iran-backed group.

The US and Saudi Arabia, along with Hezbollah's opponents in Lebanon, have ramped up calls for the group to give up arms.

But Hezbollah has pushed back, saying it would be a serious misstep to even discuss disarmament while Israel continues its air strikes on Lebanon and occupies swathes of territory in the south. Four people were killed in Israeli strikes on Wednesday.

On Friday, Lebanon's cabinet met for three hours, which included the plan's presentation by army commander Rodolphe Haykal.

Haykal had briefed ministers on the "limitations" facing the army, chief of which were Israel's continued strikes on Lebanese territory, Morcos told reporters.

He said that Israel had not yet shown any commitment to a US roadmap aimed at disarming Hezbollah in exchange for a halt to Israeli military operations in Lebanon, and which the cabinet approved last month.

"Accordingly, Lebanon clarifies that any progress towards implementing the paper remains contingent upon the commitment of the other parties, primarily Israel," Morcos said. —Reuters

Wildfires producing 'witches' brew' of air pollution, UN warns

Page 9

GENEVA: Wildfires are releasing a "witches' brew" of pollutants that can end up wrecking air quality a continent away from the blaze, the UN's weather and climate agency said on Friday.

The World Meteorological Organisation said the quality of the air people breathe was interlinked with climate change, and the two issues needed to be tackled together.

Wildfires in the Amazon, Canada and Siberia have brought home how air quality can be impacted on a vast scale, the WMO said in its fifth annual Air Quality and Climate Bulletin.

"Climate impacts and air pollution respect no national borders, as exemplified by intense heat and drought which fuels wildfires, worsening air quality for millions of people," said WMO deputy secretary-general Ko Barrett.

The bulletin looked at the interplay between air quality and the climate, highlighting the role of tiny particles called aerosols in wildfires, winter fog, shipping emissions and urban pollution.

Particles with a diameter of less than 2.5 micrometres (PM 2.5) are considered particularly harmful since they can penetrate deep into the lungs or cardiovascular system.

Wildfires led to above-average PM 2.5 levels in Canada, Siberia and central Africa last year, the WMO said. The biggest PM 2.5 surge, however, was in the Amazon basin.

Stronger, longer season

"The wildfire season has the tendency to be stronger and longer every year as a result of climate change," said WMO scientific officer Lorenzo Labrador, who coordinated the bulletin.

Wildfires in Canada have ended up causing air pollution in Europe.

"We had that last year and this year as well. So you have a degradation in air quality across continents when the meteorological conditions are right," Labrador told a press conference.

"What we have from these fires is essentially a witches' brew of components that pollute the air."

The World Health Organisation estimates

that air pollution causes more than 4.5 million premature deaths every year.

The WMO called for improved monitoring and better policies to safeguard human and environmental health—and reduce agricultural and economic losses.

The bulletin highlighted pollution hotspots in northern India. It said the Indo-Gangetic Plain had seen a marked rise in air pollution and winter fog episodes, which are growing in frequency and duration due to pollution.

Improvement in China

PM 2.5 levels continued to decline in eastern China last year, which the WMO put down to mitigation measures.

When countries take measures to combat poor air quality, the improvement can be clearly seen in meteorological data, said Paolo Laj, the WMO's global atmosphere chief.

"Look at Europe, Shanghai, Beijing, cities in the United States: many cities have taken measures and you see in the long term, a strong decrease" in recorded air pollution, he said.—AFP

Gaza film targeted by hate campaign, director says

Page 9

VENICE: At its premiere, a powerful new Gaza film at the Venice Film Festival sparked 23 minutes of sustained applause. But the next day hate emails flooded

in, the director said on Friday.

French-Tunisian director Kaouther Ben Hania's *The Voice of Hind Rajab* is a strong contender for the festival's Golden Lion, to be awarded on Saturday.

It has already garnered the support of famous Hollywood names attached as executive producers.

Between Wednesday night, after the film's premiere, and Thursday, "my producers, including the well-known American names Brad Pitt and Joaquin Phoenix, had their mailboxes flooded with thousands and thousands" of intimidating messages", Ben Hania said.

The same message, sent over and over, was "super intimidating", she added.

The film covers the last minutes of the life of a five-year-old Palestinian girl who was killed by Israeli fire last year while trying to escape Gaza with her family. It uses real-life recordings of the

desperate telephone calls she made to the Red Crescent rescue service.

Ben Hania procured the audio from the Red Crescent — with the permission of Hind Rajab's mother — but employed actors to portray the emergency workers who struggled to coordinate her rescue as Israeli tanks got ever closer.

The director has said the dramatisation is "very close to what they experienced".

Ben Hania said that, after hearing about Hind Rajab's death in January last year, she felt "a lot of anger, a lot of despair, but also a sense of 'What can I do?'"

Cast members told a press conference they felt it their "duty" to make the film.

Regardless, "I didn't make this film to keep people comfortable in their seats," Ben Hania said.

The film received strong reviews, with critics citing its emotionally

devastating audio recordings, although some pointed to a moral grey area in their use.

The *Guardian* said that, with her film, Ben Hania was "grabbing one of the most relevant issues of our time with both hands and finding a way to thrust it under our noses".

The movie, which will be released in Tunisia later this month, does not yet have a US distributor. Tunisia has already chosen the film as its entry for the Academy Awards.

Next up for the film is the Toronto International Film Festival, then festivals in London, San Sebastian (Spain) and Busan (South Korea).

The Venice premiere, the festival circuit, and a potential run for the Oscars, is "very important", Ben Hania said.

"For a film like this, it allows enormous visibility. And I want the film to be seen a little bit everywhere in the world."—AFP

Duchess of Kent dies at 92

Page 9

LONDON: Britain's Duchess of Kent, the wife of the cousin of the late Queen Elizabeth and best known for her long association with Wimbledon tennis tournament, died on Thursday. She was 92.

Born Katharine Worsley, she joined the royal family when she married Prince Edward, the Duke of Kent, in 1961 after meeting him five years earlier when he was stationed at a military barracks in northern England.

Buckingham Palace said she had passed away peacefully at her home in Kensington Palace, surrounded by her family.

"The King and Queen and all members of the royal family join the Duke of Kent, his children and grandchildren in mourning their loss and remembering fondly

the duchess's life-long devotion to all the organisations with which she was associated, her passion for music and her empathy for young people," it said in a statement.

The duchess will be best remembered for her close association with Wimbledon, where from 1969 she helped to hand out the trophies.

She famously comforted Jana Novotna when she burst into tears after losing the singles final in 1993, literally giving her a shoulder to cry on.

"I know you will win it one day, don't worry," the duchess told her, and was proved right when Novotna won the title five years later.

However, her relationship with the tournament turned sour in 1999 after

she was refused permission to bring the 12-year-old son of a bereaved friend into the royal box.

The duchess also made headlines when she converted to Roman Catholicism in 1994.—Reuters

PM vows continued support for Palestinians at all world forums

Page 10

By Syed Irfan Raza

ISLAMABAD: Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif on Friday vowed that Pakistan will continue its unwavering support to the people of Palestine by raising the issue of genocide of Palestinians in Gaza at the hands of brutal Israeli forces, at all international forums.

The prime minister made this pledge during a meeting with Adviser to the President of Palestine on Religious Affairs and Chief Justice of the Shariat Court, Mahmoud Siddiqui Alhabash, who is leading a Palestinian delegation attending the Seerat Conference here, alongside the Imam of Al Aqsa Mosque and the Palestinian Ambassador.

"During the meeting, the prime minister conveyed his warm regards to Dr Mahmoud Abbass, President of Palestine. He reaffirmed the unwavering support of the people of Pakistan to the Palestinian cause and assured the Palestinian side that Pakistan would continue to lend its full support for the brotherly people of Palestine, who have rendered enormous sacrifices and bravely faced Israeli brutal aggression," a statement from the PM Office said.

"The prime minister further assured that he would continue to raise his voice with full force for the rights of the Palestinian people at every diplomatic forum," the press release said.

On the humanitarian situation in Gaza, the prime minister reassured the Palestinian delegation that Pakistan would continue to dispatch humanitarian assistance for the people of Gaza, who have been subjected to a man-made famine by Israeli occupation forces.

The adviser to the Palestinian president conveyed the deepest gratitude of the Palestinian people to the people and government of Pakistan for their consistent and unflinching support.

Recalling the longstanding and historic bonds between the people of Pakistan and Palestine, they said that Pakistan was a source of strength for them in this difficult time. The Palestinian side also offered their condolences over the recent floods in Pakistan.

At the end of the meeting, a letter from President Mahmoud Abbas was also handed over to the prime minister.

Singer QB injured in brown bear attack at Deosai

Page 10

By Jamil Nagri

GILGIT: Singer Quratulain Balouch sustained injuries on Thursday night after being attacked by a rare Himalayan brown bear during a camping trip in Deosai National Park, prompting authorities to impose a ban on camping in the area, officials said.

The singer, popularly known as QB, was camping with two others for filming near Bara Pani when the bear attacked, injuring both of her arms with its claws and teeth. However, her cameraman and other companion remained unharmed, GB police spokesperson Ghulam Muhammad said.

Her screams eventually forced the bear to retreat, and wildlife staff stationed near the campsite quickly intervened, sources said. They administered first aid and transported her to RHQ Hospital Skardu, where doctors confirmed she is out of danger.

After the attack, the Gilgit-Baltistan government imposed an immediate ban on all camping in Deosai National Park.

"In future, no traveller or tourist will be able to camp at night," GB government spokesperson



QURATULAIN Balouch

Faizullah Faraq said in a statement, confirming the injured singer is out of danger.

Police have launched an investigation into the incident.

The Himalayan brown bear, native to Deosai, often moves toward the Bara Pani area in search of food. Similar attacks have occurred in the past, Ghulam Muhammad said. The endangered bear population in the park is estimated to be just 77.

Stretching between Skardu and Astore districts, Deosai National Park is a major summer attraction for national and international tourists. Authorities have urged visitors to exercise caution and pitch camps closer to hotels or designated safe zones.

19 killed as Israel razes high-rise in Gaza City

• US sanctions three Palestinian human rights organisations • WHO chief urges Tel Aviv to stop starving people to death

GAZA CITY: The Israeli military intensified its bombardment in Gaza City on Friday, demolishing a high-rise building it claimed was used by Hamas, as part of its campaign to take over control of the area.

In a statement, the military said it had “identified significant Hamas terrorist activity within a wide variety of infrastructure sites in Gaza City, and particularly in high-rise buildings,” adding it would target those sites “in the coming days”.

Less than an hour later, it announced it had struck one such building, accusing Hamas of using it “to advance and execute attacks against troops in the area.”

19 killed in Gaza

Israeli strikes killed at least 19 people in and around Gaza City, an area the Israeli military is planning to conquer.

Civil defence spokesman Mahmud Bassal said that attacks targeted buildings and tents sheltering displaced Gazans in various neighbourhoods and city outskirts.

Israeli Defence Minister Israel

Katz vowed to intensify operations, with Israeli military spokesman Nadav Shoshani saying on Thursday that the start of the campaign to seize Gaza City will not be announced in advance to “maintain the element of surprise”.

Hamas video release

Also on Friday, Hamas released a video of two Israeli prisoners, with one captive saying he was being held in Gaza City. The edited video featured an exhausted-looking Guy Gilboa-Dalal, 24, who said he feared being killed by Israel’s offensive.

Gilboa-Dalal and Alon Ohel, who is also seen briefly in the video, is among 48 people still held by Hamas in Gaza, with 20 of them thought to be alive.

US sanctions

On the diplomatic front, the United States on Thursday imposed sanctions on three leading Palestinian human rights organisations.

The US State Department designated Al-Haq, Al Mezan Center for Human Rights, and the Palestinian

Centre for Human Rights, stating they “have directly engaged in efforts by the International Criminal Court to investigate, arrest, detain, or prosecute Israeli nationals, without Israel’s consent”. The decision drew swift condemnation. UN Human Rights Chief Volker Turk called the move “completely unacceptable,” saying the sanctions would have a “chilling effect”.

WHO appeal

The World Health Organisation (WHO) chief on Friday urged Israel to stop the “catastrophe” of people starving to death in Gaza, saying at least 370 people have died from malnutrition since the war began.

“This is a catastrophe that Israel could have prevented, and could stop at any time,” WHO Director-General Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus told reporters. “Starvation of civilians as a method of war is a war crime that can never be tolerated.”

Israel has denied famine, insisting the territory was suffering from a “man-made shortage engineered by Hamas”.—Agencies